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THE GOOD THE BAD THE CYBER BUDDHA

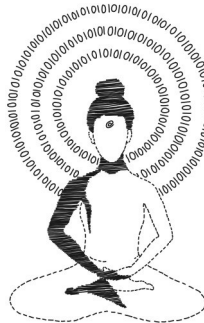
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CYBER BUDDHA

The Good The Bad The Cyber Buddha

Paathik Muni
Kamaljeet Kaur Muni

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The Good The Bad The Cyber Buddha

Paathik Muni

Kamaljeet Kaur Muni

First Edition: July, 2022

ISBN Number: 978-93-92428-03-6

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REVIEWS

The Good The Bad The Cyber Buddha as a concept and a series of practices is an amazing way of articulating and elucidating one of the most important themes of our times - identity and personal data privacy and security. Paathik Muni and Kamaljeet Kaur, through a very real life approach to this urgent reality, has made a very valuable contribution to the body of knowledge on this subject.

Most organisations have built firewalls and security systems that guard corporate networks and data like Fort Knox in the US or the RBI in India, but all too often, the careless habits of people can put all these corporate efforts to naught. And while end point security can be provided in the office environment, the responsibility to be on guard against malicious intruders and data thieves is a responsibility that every individual owns and has to take very seriously.

I recommend this book, not only for laymen but also people who think they know it all, but are still vulnerable !

Dr Ganesh Natrajan

Director, Center for AI & Advanced Analytics and
Chairman, NASSCOM Foundation

I would recommend this book to everyone who has ever created an email account, owns a smart phone or drives a car with a CPU inside it. As technology takes a leap, the avenues which “The Bad” folks take to exploit the “The Good” keeps getting wider. Hence its imperative that we prepare ourselves with the knowledge in this book, to become the “Cyber Buddha” and be as relaxed as a monk, while surfing the tech wave. As humans, the most common instinct we all have is to lock our doors and windows behind us. We do this not just for privacy, but also for security. This book made me realise that the most important window to our private and professional life, our digital devices, are left unsecured by us most of the time. The beauty of this book, is that it taught me a few great lessons, while keeping me entertained with its narrative. Paathik and Kamal have in a way, invented a new form of story telling in this genre. They have created some fictional characters, who feel and behave so much like people in our friend circle, that we connect with them instantly. Using those relatable characters Paathik and Kamal warn us about the most common mistakes we do, while taking our cyber safety for granted and what are the easy steps we can follow to avoid becoming a victim. So, please read the book and pass it on to someone you genuinely care about. Lets all be safe.

Gopal Kulkarni

Writer, CID series on Sony TV

This book is informative and engaging at the same time. The writer has smartly woven all the do's and don'ts into a casual-fun conversation which makes it an easy and enjoyable read.

Chirag Kakkad

Writer, Crime Patrol series on Sony TV

The Good The bad The Cyber Buddha, What an amazing read, the writer chooses an extremely creative ways to demonstrate our day to day digital practices. The stories are very relatable and some of them even made me reconsider my ways of surfing on the internet and staying secured!

Harshil Shah

Dadasaheb Phalke Award winning Writer.

I found The Good The Bad The Cyber Buddha very informative for people who are not so tech savvy and have started enjoying putting everything about their life on Facebook and Instagram, the dangers of half knowledge. It's an eye opener as to how simple it is for someone to pull apart your life.

Varsha Taurani

Owner, TIPS Industries Ltd

This book educates every individual on digitally safeguarding themselves, this book is a go to bible on Cyber safety. Simple, engaging and vastly relatable!

Ravi Ranjan

Shark Tank India, Government Advisor
(Entrepreneurship)

This book by my good friend, Paathik Muni, comes at a very timely juncture in our lives. Due to the pandemic, our digital presence have grown and we are spending increasing amounts of time and money online. Fraudsters have been quick to notice this and taken advantage of it. We all need to become more vigilant. I strongly recommend this book to all of us and our family members. It's filled with insightful examples and helpful nuggets of wisdom. Must-read!

KK Mookhey

Founder, NII Consulting

A very insightful read. People always take cyber security lightly. Everybody thinks they cannot become a victim to this kind of fraud, but we are much more vulnerable than we think.

In this book, Paathik & Kamal puts a very interesting twist to something which is very technical to understand

otherwise, and makes things much more relatable and easy-to-understand.

Anuraag Gambhir

Director, Shopclues

A riveting anecdotal read, keeps you in the story looking for more. With a subtle message on managing your cyber safety, the stories are full of examples on how we compromise ourselves without thinking.

Himanshu Asthana

DGM, SIDBI

A riveting read. Paathik & Kamal have delivered a perspective of the cyber world that is so different from everything else that's out there. OUTSTANDING STORY TELLING, CANDID AND INSIGHTFUL. Read it to get going...

Hardik Kapdi

Managing Partner, Ecosys OOH

(Part of Publicis Groupe)



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FOREWORD

The word Cyber Safety conjures up visions of nerds in thick glasses behind large computer screens, busy preventing or perpetrating a cyber intrusion. But the reality is - Cyber Safety is a part of life. Everything from your handheld, to laptop to the many digital devices that we use are susceptible to cyber threats. Safety rests in preventing such threats. These preventive measures are in our control through simple rules of safety - the subject of this engaging book.

The topic of common-sense safety in the cyber world takes a refreshing turn in the narrative of this book. The book explains threats cyber environment presents and outlines simple antidotes all of us can adopt in our lives. But the word Cyber comes in the way of humanizing and simplifying this subject. This is where the journey of the characters in this book brings us to the world of Cyber Safety humanely; democratizing knowledge in this field so that anyone can detect and prevent threats lurking at every cyber corner.

The nature of cyber threats is still not fully understood, just as cyber activity has ballooned. By some accounts just in the past 5 years cyber traffic over the net has ballooned by 60x times. The world was going digital, and COVID accelerated this move at warp speed. And yet

cyber activity remains hidden from the naked eye, even as we continue to increase cyber actions in a normal day. In this situation, no one is free from the impact of these threats. From young students, to housewives, to corporate executives and increasingly schoolteachers, farmers, mechanics, army personnel, the restaurant owner, and others must cope with cyber security and create an envelope of safety around them.

Digital acceleration has also created strategic decentralization in India and the world. Activity has moved from central offices to homes, restaurants, trains and cars, and small towns and districts. In such situations every individual is now charged with the responsibility of creating a secure cyber environment, not just the IT folks in the office. This digital decentralization has to be matched by the democratization of cyber security - starting with knowledge and solutions of possible threats. This book fills that gap in a refreshing, engaging manner that makes you want to read on.

Paathik and Kamal have woven a vibrant story of what constitutes cyber threats and what can be done to prevent such breaches through stories and conversations. Paathik's own humanity is also present in the book as its protagonist. The book not only brings out knowledge, it brings out the author himself as a passionate, personal advocate of cyber safety. A person, who has an unenviable track record in the business world, but who has contributed to society through different forums. A person who has an insatiable hunger to learn more, and therefore he has embarked on a career of legal training late in life. These aspects of his persona, the simplicity of his explanations are a key part of the book. And as he

walks down this cyber trail with the reader, his character makes the book come alive.

I wish the reader the same enjoyment and pleasure, not to mention knowledge, I got reading the book. I recommend the book not only to those who address the issues of cyber security professionally, but also to lay people – students, teachers, business executives, housewife's, who perhaps need this knowledge even more. Not only will it give you insights to navigate the seemingly opaque world of cyber space security, it will also make for a good read and put your trust back in cyber space. This trust in the cyber space environment is an essential to dealing with the world in the years to come.

Shashank Mani Tripathi

Partner - PWC, Government Strategy &
Transformation.

PREFACE/AUTHOR'S NOTE

Like you all, I too always thought that cyber attackers only targeted amateurs or people who weren't tech savvy, like our parents or grandparents. But that belief was challenged by an observation I made while I was studying at Stanford. It's no secret that Stanford houses some of the most brilliant minds in the world, who understood the value of cyber safety. I saw them all using world-class software and popular tools to protect their cyber life, but even then, they weren't spared when it came to cyber- attacks.

That's when it dawned on me - cyber safety isn't just about anti-virus software or protection tools; it's all about you and your habits.

It was then that I decided to write a book. And, trust me, it was easier said than done. The idea was simple – explain the pitfalls of cyberspace to every reader in the most simplistic and entertaining manner. Now, the challenge was to actually do it. So, as any good husband would do, I shared this idea with my wife Kamal and she, being an expert in the digitisation space, certified that there was a clear need for such a book from the user's perspective.

The next couple of months saw an influx of coffees, conversations, consultations, and sleepless nights. Kamal

helped me put together the bones of this book, and it was her genius idea to deliver the content in the form of exciting stories. As stories are the best delivery instrument, especially when talking about a lacklustre subject like safety and security, I too readily agreed. And thus, *The Good The Bad The Cyber Buddha* was born. Although, that wasn't what it was called back then.

While I was writing the book, I had a few discussions with friends and co-workers on the topic. It further reassured me that I was on the right track. One of the key insights from these discussions was that every individual with an internet-active device felt that nothing wrong could ever happen to them. However, this notion has been debunked over and over by statistics in the digital world. This is primarily because although these devices make our lives simpler, they also act as easy entry points to our lives for antisocial elements.

I'm pretty sure that each one of us tech-savvy individuals would have faced or at least know of someone who has faced one or the other form of digital loss, whether be it OTP/wallet fraud or hacking of digital profiles or e-commerce frauds. The bad of the digital world has touched some part of everyone's lives for sure, and if you are not part of this list, consider yourself lucky.

In my career as a Cyberspace expert, I have seen many people falling prey to these. It made me wonder why these crimes occurred, and on further pondering, I concluded that most of these bad events in the digital space occurred due to some very peculiar habits. *The Good The Bad The Cyber Buddha* focuses on these habits and gives simple, clear, easy-to-adopt solutions that can make everyone more cyber safe.

The other objective of this book is to clear the misconceptions about safety and security in cyberspace. Cyber Security may sound complex, and we all tend to relate this to the expertise of an IT professional. But truth be told, this is because the security industry always advertises the fear of loss, just like any insurance company, requiring high-tech interventions and specialist services. But it's not always that complicated.

Let me break it down for you. While Cyber Security is at the network level and managed by an organization, Cyber Safety is in the hands of every user. Some of the most prominent cyber breaches known to the public, including Stuxnet or the Sony hack, have happened at the user device level; not at the network level.

That should be reason enough for you to take Cyber Safety seriously. And since you're holding a copy of this book in your hands, I'd say that you already know that. Kudos!

Through this book, I highlight certain habits, which we are all guilty of, that can leave us vulnerable in cyberspace and discuss possible ways to correct them without disrupting your everyday life. And don't worry, this book is an easy read for everyone and not just the techies. I've left out the technical jargon and tried to explain the problems in story format to the best of my abilities. You will also find interesting and relatable characters who explain to you the concepts and mitigation, through their fun and lively conversations. I've even included a small game at the end of this book as a quick recap and for you to check your Cyber Buddha score.

Lastly, I would like to state that all the stories and

anecdotes used in the book are drawn from real-life instances from my professional and personal experiences. I have just fictionalized them a bit for your reading pleasure. I think I've said more than enough. Happy reading and after the read, please don't add the book to your collection, rather gift it to another person that you think can benefit the most in your circle of influence.

With much gratitude,

Paathik Muni

CHARACTER DESCRIPTIONS

PIYUSHI JAIN



Piyushi Jain is a pretty girl in her twenties with a zest for life. She has always been good at juggling academics and extracurriculars. Her friends describe her as fun-loving, soft-spoken, talented and outgoing. While she was born in the small city of Jaipur, her education brought her to the

Maximum City of Mumbai, and now, she finds it difficult to leave. After some stints in the marketing world, Piyushi set out on her own to launch, Erus The Label, a range of luxury lifestyle products.

She loves a good party and will never miss an opportunity to have a good time with her BFFs. In the past, she attended a few house parties organized by Shrinivas and loved the concept of meeting strangers who share the same interests. She finally decided to host one at her apartment, where the theme would be personal stories. She thought of it as a chance to make new connections, learn new things and listen to interesting tales. The stories at the party take a turn into the cyberspace world when Paathik learns that she intends to hand her phone over to a service centre after accidentally dropping it in a bucket of water.

SHRINIVAS SHINDE



Shrini, as he is widely known, is an enterprising young man who has always followed his passion, no matter where it took him. He is a fitness enthusiast, an ace cricketer by passion and a businessman by profession. He is tall, athletic in build and has a warm, welcoming smile. 'A man of few words and

countless ideas' is apt to describe his persona.

One fine day, Shrini stumbled upon Airbnb. He fell in love with the concept of allowing strangers to live in your home and experience a city like a local. And that's where the idea of his company, Playace, was born. It's built as a place where like-minded strangers can meet, interact and have fun. Today, Playace has hosted over 1200 house parties across Mumbai and Pune, with over 7000 guests in attendance. As the party organizer, Shrini is always helpful, meticulous and ready with an intelligent quip to lighten the mood.

Being always alert and very cautious, Shrini doesn't have any personal cybercrime stories to recount. But that doesn't stop him from contributing to those he's witnessed or heard about. If there's one takeaway for Shrini from this house party, it's how unique passwords can be created from personal experiences. Using his own story of a Halloween party, Paathik shows him how a unique, and more importantly, impenetrable password can be formed.

YUVRAJ WALMIKI



From a life of significant hardships, Yuvraj Walmiki rose to become the Prince of Indian Hockey through perseverance and commitment. As a 10-year-old boy, he dreamt of seeing his picture in the newspaper and made it come true with his first official match. But it was the 2011 Asian Champions

Trophy win that catapulted him to fame. He still considers that moment as one of his proudest achievements. A grand welcome awaited him back home on his arrival after securing the crucial goal that led to India's victory against Pakistan. But fame and fortune haven't changed Yuvraj's modest nature even in the slightest way. He attends the party with Paathik to fuel his interest in meeting new people and hearing their stories.

Being a celebrity, both online and offline, and a digital-savvy person, Yuvraj has seen and heard his fair share of cybercrime stories. While he usually watches what he speaks, he quickly gets comfortable with the group and shares some cybercrime accounts that he has been a witness to – even one that involved his brother and celebrity hockey player, Devindar.

MANBIR SINGH



From a very young age, Manbir was fashion-conscious. He would insist on choosing his clothes and, as he grew up, didn't even like repeating an outfit. Not surprisingly, he has an opinion on fashion and everything in the world of glitz and glamour. While in college, he started reviewing fashion looks on

YouTube – the good and the bad. He grew in popularity – from being known in college to being known in the city too. Since he was new to Mumbai, Manbir saw the advertised house party as a great place to meet new people. Of course, getting his name out in the right circles would help too.

Being in front of the camera often, Manbir is very comfortable in a crowd of new people and is usually found to be the one breaking the ice and starting conversations. That's seen throughout the story as he quickly gels with the rest of the group. The stories recounted at the party led him to realize that he too was unknowingly a cybercrime victim, which he learnt was all because of a nasty habit.

GHAZAL KHAN



Ghazal was born and brought up in the Gulf but returned to Mumbai to pursue further studies. She's the only child and is used to being the center of attention, but it's not something she craves. While her family is conservative, they brought her up with a modern and open-minded approach –

something that she is ever grateful for. It's what has moulded her into an open, honest and fun-loving person.

Being a content writer in an ad agency and an avid reader, the storytelling theme at the advertised house party instantly drew her attention. "There's never a wrong time to be exposed to new stories," she always says. At the party, Ghazal immediately clicks with Piyushi, owing to their shared love for books. But that's not to say she didn't get along with the other guests. Her passion for books compelled her to start a blog back in college, but her eagerness to gain popularity landed her in a tight spot. Being embarrassed by her experience, Ghazal was first hesitant to share the story. However, after finding herself in good company (and in good spirits), she narrates her encounter as a cybercrime victim.

PAATHIK MUNI



Paathik is someone who keeps his eyes open and his mind active at all times. He is a powerhouse of ideas and energy. You will never see him idling away time, and even when it seems so, you can be sure that his mind is busy piecing together some new bit of information. He began in the computer industry,

graduated to the telecom industry, and eventually moved into life in cyberspace. He won't distinguish himself as a nerd, but he loves to learn every aspect of a subject of interest. He believes that "if you want a son to grow up into a man you can be proud of, be a man he can be proud of." With this always at the back of his mind, he's gone on to collect multiple degrees and achievements.

In a social setting, Paathik is energetic, obliging, open and friendly. He loves to share his stories with friends and strangers alike. He is confident in his presentation and has a wicked sense of humour. He loves to meet new people and has attended a few house parties, where he met Shrini and Piyushi. After multiple interactions with Shrini, Paathik went on to sign up Playace as a client too. When invited to this house party, he was instantly drawn by the storytelling theme and convinced his friend, Yuvraj, to join him. At the party, he's happy to see everyone take a keen interest in cyber safety and is amazed by the number of stories he hears. Using his expertise in cyberspace, he quickly clarifies and advises the group on how those situations could have been averted.

ELSA D'SILVA



Having spent a decade in the aviation industry, Elsa D'silva now uses her data-driven background and her in-depth knowledge of technology to empower women. Her first venture outside the aviation industry was developing the Safecity platform, which armed women with information about safe and

dangerous spaces in and around their location. With a host of awards and recognitions under her belt, Elsa saw this house party as one where she could meet new people and hear new stories.

She is a natural leader who doesn't shy away from voicing her opinion and basking in the limelight. With her confident personality, she brings an air of maturity and knowledge to the party. That's not all. She also recounts a recent experience where her friend was a victim of skimming at a restaurant.

CHAPTERS

1. WELCOME TO THE PARTY
2. SHARING IS NOT ALWAYS CARING
3. SHARE SECRETS, NOT PASSWORDS
4. THE COMMON PROBLEM OF THE UNCOMMON PASSWORD
5. A SHUT DEVICE CATCHES NO SPIES
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WELCOME TO THE PARTY

The phone beeps on the kitchen counter. Its owner, a young girl in her mid-twenties, who is busy emptying the bag of chips into a glass bowl, sets it aside with haste to check her latest message. She quickly types in a reply and keeps her phone aside before checking her dainty watch to realise it's almost time for her guests to arrive. She picks up the empty chip packets with a swift motion and throws them in the bin hiding in a dark corner under the sink. It's time for some clean-up now for the house and its host.

Tidying up done, she makes her way to the sanctum of her humble home - the bedroom. She slides the wooden door of her wardrobe with a little effort. It's time to oil the brackets; she makes a mental note for later. It's funny how when you have guests coming over; you end up scanning your home under a microscope. She quickly peeks into the living room to make sure everything is in its place.

The living room was decked up too. Fairy lights hung loosely around the window, smiling at their own reflection. Colourful cushions sat propped up on the windowsill, showing off their vibrant hues. On the purple couch across from the window lay a beige knitted throw blanket lazily as though claiming its rightful place. The matching chairs on either side of the couch seemed to be

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engaged in a staring contest with each other from across the coffee table.

The walls of the living room were boasting artworks, some personal and others professional. It was all in good taste, though. A wooden bookshelf stood in one corner, flaunting the masterpieces it had collected over the years.

Satisfied with what she sees, she has no time to dilly-dally. She picks out a mustard yellow summer dress and makes her way to the bathroom. A few minutes later, she emerges in panic from the bathroom while holding a phone that's dripping wet. Looking visibly frazzled, she quickly takes out a towel and starts wiping down the phone on all sides. She goes into the kitchen and takes out a container with rice. Gently pushing her phone into the container, she silently prays that her phone would come back to life. Her guests would be here soon, leaving her no time for wallowing. She quickly dabs on some makeup and spritzes her perfume, before giving herself one last glance in the mirror. She closes the bedroom door behind her as she makes her way out.

Just then, the doorbell announces her first guest. She takes a deep breath, shake off the panic, and puts on a smile. *She will deal with the phone later*, she thinks as she opens the door. A tall young man with a trimmed beard stands enters panting. "Hello, Piyushi! Glad to have finally made it," he says with a grin, "I was almost in panic mode when I couldn't get through to your number. Thankfully, the watchman saw me go up and down your lane so many times, that he asked me where I wanted to go. Since, he knows your name he was able to confirm that I was in the right building." "I'm sooo sorry Shrini," Piyushi apologizes, "My phone is not working and so I

can't receive or make calls. And of all the days, this had to happen today!" "Oh! What happened?" Shrini asks concerned. "Let me get you something to drink first. You look tired. Please make yourself comfortable." Piyushi leaves the room and returns shortly with a glass of water and a can of chilled juice.

Handing out the options to Shrini, she starts narrating the mishap from earlier. "So, what happened was, I had taken the phone with me to the bathroom so that I don't miss any calls while I did my makeup. I placed it on the side of the sink and by mistake my hand knocked it into a bucket of water sitting under the sink. It is now recuperating in a rice container," Piyushi says, crossing her fingers "Oh no!" Shrini exclaims, "that's really sad. If that doesn't work, you can surely get it repaired at a service centre." "I'd have to go to Dubai for that," Piyushi explains, "since I got the phone from there, and it doesn't come with international warranty. If it doesn't startup after leaving it in the rice all night, I'll take it to a mobile repair shop in the market.

With a hug, Shrini consoles, "Don't worry. Rice should hopefully do the trick. Anyway, I'll take charge of giving directions to all the guests today." "Can you also take care of the music? The speakers are right there on the table, next to my laptop," Piyushi points. Shrini nods and makes his way to the table and starts fidgeting with his phone.

The doorbell rings again, and new guests arrive at the house. A young woman in a colourful kurti and cat-eyed glasses enters, followed by two striking gentlemen. She greets Piyushi with a friendly smile, and Shrini welcomes her with a handshake. Shrini quickly turns his attention to

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both the men standing behind the woman. With a big smile and a warm hug, Shrini exclaims, "Hey, welcome Paathik. It's been long since I saw you at our parties." The man in a crisp white shirt and blue denim reciprocates, "Thank you, Shrini. Yeah, I've been keeping busy. But, I'm back." Paathik makes his way to greet the hostess of the party, "Hey Piyushi! Long time, no see." Meanwhile Shrini acknowledges the man standing by the door in a black tee and baseball cap. The young man removes his cap as Shrini announces, "Our celebrity guest has arrived! We are so honoured to have you here, Yuvraj. I'm a personal fan." Yuvraj blushes and thanks Shrini for the warm welcome.

They all make their way to the living room and find themselves a comfortable seat. Piyushi looks at the only other girl in the room, "You must be Ghazal, right? I love what you're wearing." Ghazal adjusts her kurti and smiles at Piyushi. "Thanks, and yes, I'm Ghazal Khan. I must say, the first thing I noticed about your beautiful home is the bookshelf. I'd love to browse through the collection later."

Just then, the doorbell rings and Piyushi gets up to answer it. On her way to the door, she turns to Ghazal and says, "Surely, be my guest."

The door opens, and a woman enters in semi-formal purple top and black trousers. She greets Piyushi and gives her a small gift bag. Piyushi reluctantly accepts the gift and points her to a vacant seat on the couch. After sitting down, she looks around and remarks, "Looks like we have a full house."

Shrini's phone buzzes and after a few minutes of some furious typing, he stands up and says, "Looks like

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most of us are here. One of our guests is running a bit late. Why don't we grab our drinks and start with the party?" Everyone agrees and follows Piyushi to the dining table.

With drinks in hand, the guests are now back in their seats. Piyushi sets down a bowl of chips and a dip on the centre table, within reach of her guests.

From his corner seat on the window sit-out, Shrini calls for everyone's attention. "Hello, guys! Hope you are all comfortable and ready for a fun night." The crowd responds with a "Yay!" "Let me formally introduce myself. I'm Shrini, the organiser of this party or, as I would like to call it, the CFO – Chief Fun Organizer." He pauses as the crowd bursts into a fit of laughter. He chuckles and continues, "Anyway, today we are gathered at this beautiful home to share our stories. There are no rules to our Storytellers Night except that these stories should NOT put us to sleep," he mimics a yawn before carrying on.

"So, I'm excited for the night ahead. But, before we begin, I would like to thank Piyushi," Shrini turns to the girl in the mustard dress, "for welcoming us all into her home." Piyushi mouths the words "Thank you" back at Shrini. "She's been a firecracker at the other parties I've planned, and this is the first time she's hosting."

Turning back to Piyushi, he continues, "Since you know how this goes, why don't you be first to break the icy wall with a short introduction."

"Surely, Shrini. Hello everyone," Piyushi replies, flashing her million-dollar smile. "I'm pretty excited about tonight." She points to her bookshelf and continues, "As

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you can see, stories in any form are my weakness, whether it's movies, art, or even a good book."

And today, I'm hoping to hear many interesting ones," she continues as she brushes aside a stray strand of hair from her face. "I'm the co-founder of a handmade jewellery brand, *Erus The Label* – it's a fusion of western and Indian jewellery styles that I started in early 2021," Piyushi declares with a hint of pride as she strokes the piece that adorns her neck. "Oh wow! That's gorgeous!" Ghazal gushes, moving closer to Piyushi to get a better look, "I must connect with you on this later." With an excited smile, Piyushi replies, "Sure! I'll tell you where you can find the designs too. Anyway, getting back to my introduction. I love to party and hang out with friends. I am also a trained classical dancer and an avid reader." Saying that she sits back down. After a chorus of 'Hi Piyushi' from the crowd, Shrini turns to Yuvraj and announces that they have a celebrity in their midst, gesturing towards the young man who dismisses the statement with an embarrassed smile. He introduces himself to the room.

"Hi, everyone. I'm Yuvraj Walmiki," he says as he scans everyone's faces. "I'm a professional hockey player and have had the privilege of representing India internationally." "You are too modest, Yuvraj," Shrini chimes in, "We all know that you, the Prince of Indian Hockey, scored the winning penalty goal against Pakistan at the Asian Champion's Trophy." Yuvraj nods and says, "Yeah, that is still a big achievement for me. I will never forget the day we landed with the trophy at Mumbai airport. There were thousands of people waiting to receive me. I was overwhelmed." "I can only imagine how that

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would have felt," Shrini adds, "I've always dreamt of playing cricket for the country, and I had even rigorously trained for the IPL. Unfortunately, a couple of weeks before the camp, I came down with dengue, and all my training went down the drain. It made me too weak to pass the fitness test." As echoes of sympathy fill the room, Yuvraj comments, "Man, that is brutal." Shrini brushes it off, saying, "It's okay. Life has its plans, and I like where it has brought me. Anyway, enough about me. Let's continue with the introductions."

"I'll go next," remarks the lady sitting beside Piyushi, "Hi, I'm Elsa D'silva, a social entrepreneur and founder of Safecity. It's a crowdsourced platform that gathers sexual harassment stories and maps them to create local hotspots." "I'm sure all the girls here can name a few places that will surely be on the list," remarks Ghazal.

"Yes," Elsa confirms, "and we created the platform to make you aware of the other places." "I'm making a mental note to check it out later," Piyushi declares. "Please do, and let me know what you think. Anyway, I'm really excited to get to know everyone here." Just as she is trailing off, the doorbell rings. When Piyushi opens the door, a sharply dressed young man with an apologetic look enters, saying, "Hey, I'm really sorry for getting here late. I got lost in these small lanes." As he settles down on an empty bean bag, Shrini addresses him, "Don't worry, you haven't missed much. We had just started with everyone's introductions. So, why don't you go next? Tell us about yourself."

"Hey everyone, I'm Manbir Singh, and I run a YouTube channel that reviews the latest fashion trends," he explains. "Oh, I hope you don't judge me for the way

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I'm dressed today," Paathik jokes. "Not at all. You are looking dapper," Manbir compliments and continues, "I moved here from Delhi for a project and hardly know anyone in the city. I thought this party would be a good way to get to know people," he adds as he gestures to everyone present. "Welcome, Manbir. To the party and the city," Shrini announces, "I'm sure you'll leave tonight having made some new friends." His gaze falls on Ghazal as he continues, "Why don't you go next?"

"Hey guys, I'm Ghazal Khan, a content writer at an ad agency. Like Piyushi, I also have some formal training in classical dance. The reason I signed up for this party is because of the storytelling theme, and it's my first time in this kind of a setting, so," she trails off as she smiles and crosses her fingers.

"So that leaves me," Paathik says, "I'm Paathik Muni, and I've actually been to a few of Shrini's parties, and they've always been fun! In fact, that's why I convinced Yuvraj to come with me today. And after tonight, I'm sure he'll become a regular. When it comes to work, I've been an entrepreneur all my life. I started off with a cyber cafe that was ahead of its time and then professionally refurbished mobile phones. I even co-founded a telecom roaming hub with a network of over 650 mobile operators globally. But some years back, after thoroughly exploring the telecom industry, I found cyberspace to be very appealing. Now I am the co-founder of a cyberspace consulting firm, where we help cybercrime victims get justice. My specialization though is the world of IP – Intellectual Property."

"It must be very technical and complicated, I'm sure," Ghazal presumes. "Arre, what I do may sound

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complicated, but it's really not," Paathik explains, "you'd actually be surprised to know how much it's related to what you do every day. Let me just say that if you own a phone, a computer and a Debit Card, you're already deep inside the cyber world." Paathik pauses before saying, "but that's a story for another day. Let's get the party going."

"Hey, you left out something very important, Paathik," Shrini chimes in and then addresses everyone else, "This man also co-founded Khaana Chahiye, an NGO that was set up during the first coronavirus lockdown and aimed to combat hunger." "Oh yeah!" Piyushi exclaims, "I think a friend of mine had shared an article about it. Wait I'll show it to you." She tries to fish for her phone in her pocket only to realise that it wasn't there. "Sorry, I forgot that my phone fell into water earlier today," Piyushi says with a frown. "No wonder, you're not looking your usual bubbly self today," Paathik notices, "The Piyushi I met at the last party I attended was quite different." Piyushi blushes as Manbir comments, "I actually tried calling you a couple of times, and now I know why I couldn't get through. Thankfully Shrini helped me out."

"Oh! Sorry about that," Piyushi states." Out of concern, Ghazal suggests, "I've heard that blow drying could help." "For now, I've kept it in a rice container," remarks Piyushi, "but if it doesn't work, I'm taking it to the repair shop tomorrow." "Is it under warranty?" Elsa asks. "Not right now," Piyushi confirms, "but anyway I had purchased it from abroad, and the warranty doesn't apply here." "Well, at least with Google photos and all, your data will be backed up. Don't worry," Manbir

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consoles her.

Yuvraj adds, “Something similar happened to a friend of mine. He spilled water on his laptop and got it serviced at the repair centre. All his data was recovered.” “The scary part isn’t about the backed-up data,” Paathik interjects, “but that the phone, along with all the data will be given away to a repair guy. Yuvraj, I’m sure your friend would have had to share his password with him.” After a nod from Yuvraj, Paathik continues, “Now that’s the problem. It’s not just access to your phone but access to everything you do and own digitally. This includes any notes, pictures, videos, and contacts along with open access to your social media apps.”

“But what else can she do?” Shrini says rhetorically, “her phone won’t turn on.” “Maybe, she can give it to an authorised service centre,” Ghazal points out, “then it shouldn’t be an issue.” Paathik counters saying, “That would still leave her device and data vulnerable to a third person.” He then turns to Piyushi and advises, “You can still wipe out your phone data remotely. And don’t forget to change your social media passwords from your laptop.”

“But I’m not worried about my pictures and videos as I’m very careful about what I store on my phone. There’s nothing embarrassing on it.” Piyushi says with conviction. “Well, it’s not always as simple as that,” Paathik clarifies, “even something like access to email, social media accounts, or your contacts, can land you in trouble these days.”

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SHARING IS NOT ALWAYS CARING

Paathik takes a big sip of his beer and thinks out loud, “Hmmm, let me give you an example, and quite a recent one too.”

All eyes were affixed on Paathik as he begins, “This happens to someone from the co-working space I operate out of. For the sake of confidentiality, let’s call her Maria. She’s a young, bubbly girl, quick to make friends and trusting to a fault. We had met before, so she knew I’m a cyber expert. She actually got in touch with me directly when she started getting blackmail threats from a random number. The messages were filled with her personal pictures, which she remembered taking from her phone.”

“Are we talking about weird selfies or intimate pictures?” Piyushi asks sympathetically. “A mix of both actually,” Paathik clarifies, before continuing, “This habit of clicking nudes and other such personal pictures really baffles me.” With a nod, Elsa adds, “Couples even record themselves in the act, all in the pretext of a memory.” “Exactly!” Paathik exclaims, “They don’t understand that once it’s recorded, it can easily be compromised and get into the wrong hands.”

Concerned, Elsa asks, “Did she share those pictures with anyone?” “That’s where it gets interesting. She was sure that she didn’t share it with anyone,” Paathik

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clarifies. “So, her phone was hacked then,” Elsa presumes.

With a nod, Paathik confirms, “Correct. I examined her phone and found that there was malware installed.” “Malware?” Piyushi interrupts with a confused look on her face. “Well, it’s basically bad software. The meaning is right in the word actually - *mal*-icious soft-*ware*. It’s built to be supported by any operating system, and it’s basically the start of most cybercrime issues.”

“It’s how hackers get access to devices like your phone and laptop,” Elsa adds, “with this malware installed, they can track your device and everything you do on it.”

Ghazal, who has been quietly listening till now, starts putting the pieces of information together and supposes, “So, then in Maria’s case, the hacker used the malware to get access to all the photos on her phone? That’s scary!”

“That’s right, Ghazal,” Paathik confirms, “the malware was such that it was programmed to send all her images to an unidentified number. We then took the help of the police to track the blackmailer’s number. Surprisingly, it traced right back to the same co-working space.”

“Oh! A twist!” Shrini exclaims. “Paathik, you’re setting some high standards for the stories.” With a smile, Paathik continues, “If you find that exciting, you’ll be shocked to find out that it was actually someone she knew. After quite a bit of probing, Maria finally remembered that she had actually handed her phone over to a guy from the same co-working space. He told her that his mobile ran out of battery and needed to make an

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urgent call. She gave it to him for a few minutes without thinking twice."

"So, in that time, he planted a malware? It's that easy?" Manbir questions. "It's actually quite simple," Paathik responds, "I won't get into the details, but Maria had given him an unlocked phone, so he had complete access to it to plant the malware. While she was lucky that we found the perpetrator, not everyone is. It's a nasty habit to share any of your personal devices with anyone." Manbir is quick to come to her defence, "But what she did was quite innocent. Just helped a poor guy out and that too someone she knew. How was she to know he had these intentions?" Paathik excuses himself as he munches down some chips, "You know how much personal information your phone holds? This is why Piyushi needs to be cautious about her phone too. It doesn't have to be anything explicit. But there's a lot of data that's only for your eyes. The other mistake Maria made was that she handed the phone over to him and started chatting with someone else. If you really want to help someone out, you need to be watchful of what they're doing with your phone."

"This actually reminds me of what happened to a girl in my building," Yuvraj adds from his corner in the room. Everyone turns their gaze to Yuvraj, who sets down his phone and narrates, "She was framed by a colleague who was jealous of her performance. He tricked her by handing her a duplicate charger when she forgot hers at home. She didn't know that he had loaded a malicious program by adding a chip to that charger, which gave him access to all her files. He ended up replacing her client presentation with some defamatory content, and the poor

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thing got fired when she unknowingly shared it with the client.”

“Charger cables can be hacked too?” Piyushi says in an unsettled voice, “I’ve never heard about that.” Paathik jumps in to clarify, “Yes, it’s called juice jacking, and while it’s not common, it can be done. Technically, any piece of hardware that can run a software can be hacked. That’s why it’s best not to share any of your devices – phones, laptops, chargers, cables. If you must, then create guest profiles so that the person doesn’t have access to your data. It’s a feature that’s available on most devices these days.”

“Oh, that’s smart,” Ghazal comments, “I wouldn’t want to rudely say no if an acquaintance asks to use my phone to make a call. So, I’d rather do this.” “There’s always a way around,” Paathik declares, “you just need to be aware of it. You could even set a PIN or password to approve the upload and download of data. That way, all data transfers are in your control. In fact, I’d strongly advise against buying duplicate or used chargers for the same reason. You might have to pay more for an original, but you might be paying a higher price if something goes wrong.”

“Someone I know had warned me about using public chargers too,” Elsa reveals, “like those they used to keep at airport lounges and boarding gates.” “This issue is the exact reason why they now only have charging sockets, rather than the actual chargers,” Paathik confirms.

“Man, that was one hell of an opening story, Paathik,” Shrini affirms, “you work in quite an interesting world. It’s actually making me think about the times I’ve used someone else’s phone charger or given my phone for a

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quick call.” “Me too,” agrees Manbir, “I’m going to think twice before I ever do that again.”

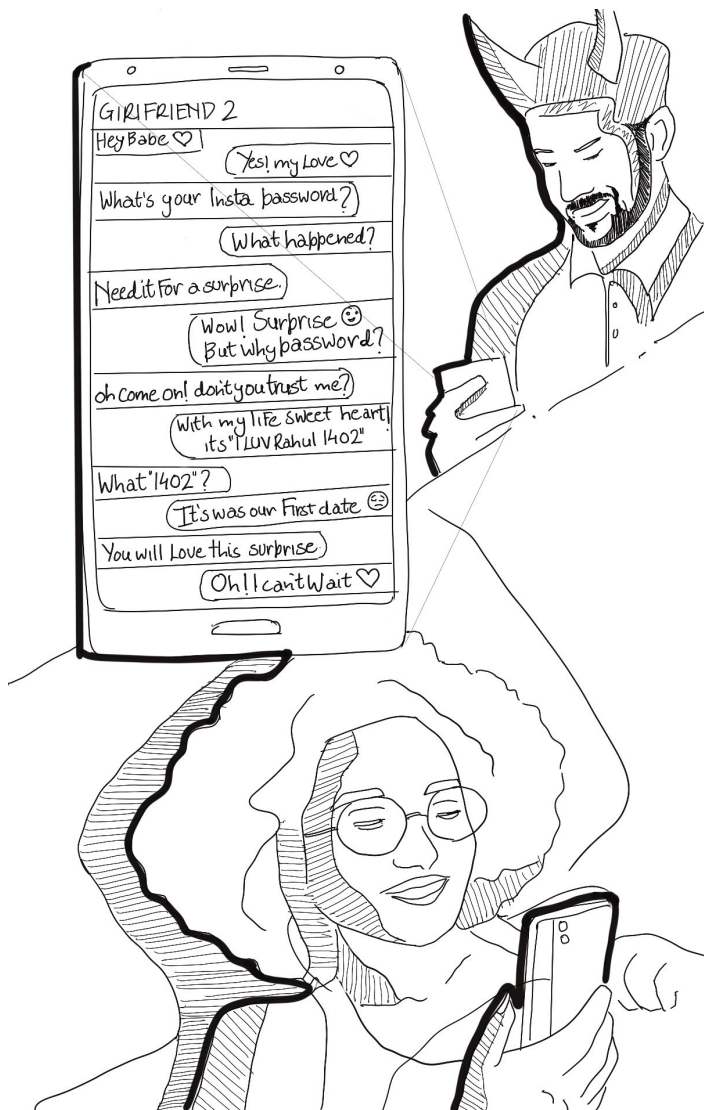
Being the ever-attentive host, Piyushi notices that the chips and dip had been a hot favourite. She excuses herself and takes the almost empty bowl to the dining table for a refill. "Would you guys like something less spicy?" Piyushi calls out. "Depends on how spicy our stories are going to get tonight," Shrini jokes. With a giggle, Ghazal gestures for Piyushi to return, calling out, "Anything will do." Just when Elsa was commenting on Maria's luck in getting her pictures back, Piyushi chimes in as she sets down the bowls, "That's true. It would have been so much worse if the pictures were published online. Someone in my college wasn't quite so lucky, though."

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SHARE SECRETS, NOT PASSWORDS

Piyushi shifts in her chair to get comfortable before she continues, "So it's quite common to share your phone unlock code with a close friend or partner, right?" With a nod, Ghazal confirms, "I've added my best friend's fingerprint to my phone. I know she means no harm."

"Well, I don't want to make any assumptions, but this story may change that habit," Piyushi cautiously warns. This girl in my college, Pooja was dating Rahul. It started off as a typical college love story – Pooja was a college sweetheart, amongst the toppers in our batch and was actively involved in college functions. Rahul, on the other hand, was known to be the rowdy one - the one who'd play pranks on the teachers and tease and trouble the girls." "Arre, this seems like the plotline of *Kuch Kuch Hota Hai*," Shrini interjects with a chuckle, "his name is also Rahul." The room fills with laughter as Yuvraj comments, "That's so Bollywood Shrini!"

"They had it easy, compared to what happened to Pooja," Piyushi comments, "A few months into their relationship, she posted some *really* intimate pictures of them on Instagram. We were all shocked because she hadn't even posted a picture of them together until then, and I knew Pooja; she's quite shy. This was completely unlike her."

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“Did her phone get hacked too?” Elsa questions. “No, no. In hindsight, she did something quite foolish, actually. She had shared her password with Rahul in an attempt to prove her loyalty.” “So, Rahul posted the pictures?” Ghazal and Shrini ask in unison.

After a quick nod from Piyushi, Ghazal continues, “But why would he do that?” Making a circular gesture with her hands, Piyushi states, “We’ll have to rewind a bit for that. You see, when college first started, Rahul pulled some prank on Pooja. She got furious and slapped him right in front of everyone in the canteen. His ego got so hurt that he decided to take revenge.” “That’s so vindictive!” exclaims Elsa, “He would have gotten more than a slap if I were in her place.”

“He would definitely deserve that,” Paathik agrees, “but it’s a lesson for all of us to never, ever, *ever* share our passwords with anyone. I trust my wife, but even she doesn’t know my password. If it ever came down to loyalty, I’d prefer to open the chat or gallery and let my partner go through it.”

“But didn’t she get an OTP or notification that someone was trying to sign in?” Manbir asks. With a shrug, Piyushi explains, “Don’t think so.” “That would have only happened if she had two-factor authentication set up,” Yuvraj adds.

Ghazal excuses herself and asks Piyushi to point her to the washroom. As she walks away, Shrini comments, “At least this girl shared it with someone she thought she could trust. I heard of someone who foolishly said it out loud in his office. A colleague who wanted to tarnish his reputation used his password to authorise some illegal company payments. That poor guy lost his job and all.”

“That’s really sad,” Piyushi exclaims.

“Pardon me for the accusation, Shrini, and I hope this isn’t a friend of yours,” Paathik interrupts, “but that’s plain foolish. It’s like leaving the door to your house wide open and going on a holiday. It’s an invitation for people who are up to no good. Passwords, in fact, should be treated like your underwear – don’t leave them lying around, don’t share them with anyone, and change them regularly.” “That’s a weird one,” Shrini chuckles as he giggles are heard across the room, “but it’s very true. I actually don’t know the guy, but I remember thinking that he should have at least changed his password after he gave it to someone, no?” “Of course,” confirms Paathik, “that would have been the smart thing to do. It would have been smarter to just not give your password to anyone.” “Yeah, I agree,” Elsa adds, “Once you share your password, that’s it. You’ve literally signed off all your data to that person. I would never share my password with anyone.”

When Ghazal re-enters the room and hears the word ‘password’, she quickly declares, “Good! We’re still on the topic of passwords. Piyushi’s story actually brought to mind what happened at the company I used to work in.” “Was it your office where someone said their password out loud?” Manbir interjects, “Because Shrini beat you to it. He just told us about that while you were in the washroom.”

“Said it out loud? No, no. In my office,” Ghazal clarifies, “the password caused a rift between teammates.”

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THE COMMON PROBLEM OF THE UNCOMMON PASSWORD

“It seems like password-related crimes are quite common in the cyberworld,” Manbir comments as he turns to Paathik for confirmation. "Of course, boss!" Paathik exclaims, "as Elsa said, it's the key to all the data you hold online. Of course, some passwords are more crucial than others. For e.g., your email password vs the password for some news site you've just signed up for.”

“But like in my story, if the passwords are the same, then it spells trouble,” adds Ghazal. “Sanjay and Rahul worked together in the business development team. While Rahul was a little reserved, Sanjay was the polar opposite. He had a way with clients; they always praised him and his work,” Ghazal pauses as she reaches for the bowl of chips. "One day, we heard that Sanjay had been fired and slapped with a defamation case because of what he had posted on LinkedIn. We checked the post, and he had gone after our clients – posted a lot of rubbish to humiliate and malign them.”

Manbir interjects, “Did someone hack into his account?” “Kind of. There was a rumour that Rahul might have gotten jealous of Sanjay hogging the limelight and decided to bring him down. It was all too easy for Rahul if you go to see since Sanjay and he shared a cabin. He

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may have openly entered his password in front of Rahul. Because we found out later that the same password had been used to access Sanjay's LinkedIn account."

The resident cybercrime expert quickly points out, "But Sanjay is to blame too in this scenario. Even if I have to type in my laptop password in a room full of people, I make sure that the keypad is positioned away from prying eyes. Otherwise, it's as good as saying your password out in the open," he explains.

Ghazal jumped to Sanjay's support, "I'm sure he trusted Rahul, and he didn't deserve all this just because of that." Paathik nods and then goes on to elaborate his point, "Firstly, you should never share your password with anyone, even by mistake. We've already seen how horribly wrong that can go. Even so, his next mistake was that he used the same password. He's lucky Rahul didn't try his bank account. Imagine if he used the same password for that too." "Hey, it's not always easy to think of new passwords for all our accounts and devices," Shrini comments.

"It can be. Let me show you. Think of an incident or story in your life that you'll never forget." Paathik turns to Piyushi, "Can you give me a piece of paper and a pen, please?" "Of course, Paathik. Can't wait to see what you are about to do next." She gets up from her chair and heads to the study table in the corner. She returns with a colourful notepad and pen, which she hands over to Paathik.

"Thanks," Paathik says, before opening up a blank page, "So, Shrini, have you thought of an incident?" Shrini asks, "Can it be my wedding day?" "No, leave out weddings, birthdays, anniversaries. It could be from one

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of your travels or your work or some random event you witnessed. It has to be something that is etched in your memory," Paathik explains. "Okay. Got it!" Shrini thinks for a moment and then replies, "So, when I was studying in London, back in 2011, I was invited to a Halloween party by a classmate, Danny. I was new to the country and didn't really know anyone, so I thought it might be a nice way to meet people. I didn't really know how seriously people took dressing up for parties there and landed up at the party wearing a skull t-shirt. Boy, was I underdressed or what? The people at the party were dressed in all sorts of scary clothes – from witches to ghosts to the twins from Shining. I felt out of place for a bit."

"Now, that would've given me nightmares for days," Ghazal says, spooked by the very thought of it. "Hahaha. But contrary to their getup, everyone was so nice and welcoming to me," Shrini continues. "After a few drinks, we were even dancing to Bollywood hits. I remember this day so well because this was the inspiration for my company. Random strangers were meeting up and sharing their thoughts, having a good time and becoming friends."

"That's really a nice one, Shrini, and it's something that you'll never forget," Paathik adds and continues, "So from the story you just said, let's coin your password. First, the year, 2011." Paathik jots down on the notepad. "Then the name of your friend – Danny. Add to that the design on your t-shirt - Skull. And finally, the place - London. Your password can be something like this 2-0-1- 1-D-a-n-n-y-S-k-u-l-l-@-L-o-n-d-o-n." Paathik turns the notepad around for everyone to see. "I challenge anyone to try to guess that password," Paathik says with a smirk.

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With a nod of approval, Shrini states, "This is easy for me to remember too." "Of course, it is," Paathik agrees, "it's made of things that are very personal to you." Addressing everyone in the room, he advises, "just remember two things when setting a password – One, don't use a birthday or anniversary. And two, make sure your password is at least 16 characters. Using stories or memorable events to create your password makes it easier for you to always remember them. You can also use a catchphrase or your favourite movie dialogue to make things easier - these are called paraphrase passwords."

"You mean something like *tumse naa ho payega*?" Manbir says with a snicker. "Yeah, that would be a fair warning to whoever is trying to access your account. Like bro, you can't do it, so why even bother." Yuvraj adds, and everyone starts laughing.

Recovering from a hearty laugh, Paathik goes on, "That was a good one! Just remember to add a layer of numbers or symbols to the dialogue. Make a set of 5 passwords like these that you can keep switching around." "This is really helpful, Paathik," Piyushi praises, "Now, I won't have to rack my brains when I go to my social media passwords like you suggested." Saying this, she gets up to go refill her glass. Manbir and Elsa follow suite.

Meanwhile, the conversation continues. "Doesn't two-factor authentication also help in case your password has been compromised?" asks Yuvraj, "Ever since my younger brother Devindar had his Instagram account hacked, I've kept that feature on. He had clicked on a link that said he'd violated Instagram policies and lost all his followers." Nodding in agreement, Paathik responds,

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“That’s true, two-factor authentication (also called two-step verification) is quiet common with social media IDs. But had Sanjay enabled that or even multi-factor authentication, Rahul wouldn’t have succeeded in accessing his account. In fact, I’d suggest that you keep two-factor authentication turned on for emails and bank accounts too.”

"I have heard about two-factor, but what is multi-factor?" Shrini asks with a puzzled look. "Well, two-factor authentication requires you to provide two types of information to establish access, whereas multi-factor authentication requires you to share more information to gain access," Paathik scratches his head as if to stimulate his brain cells, "Take a pant for example. The button is the first safety measure to stop your pants from falling. When you put on a belt, that’s an added precaution, just like two-factor authentication. Now, if you want to be absolutely safe, you wear suspenders that will come to the rescue even if your button and belt give away." "I’ll never look at my pants the same way again," Manbir quips.

As the room quietens down after the laughter riot, Yuvraj brings everyone back to the topic, "So, when multi-factor authentication is enabled, what do you enter after your password and OTP?" "Glad you asked," Paathik remarks, "It ends with something that can’t be duplicated like your biometrics. It’s basically multiple layers to stop anyone from accessing your accounts. In fact, if requested, banks will give you an additional key to securely transact online."

Elsa, who is walking back with her drink, adds, "Even our phones allow us to enable two-factor authentication." Paathik nods in agreement. "Hey guys, does anyone else

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need a refill?" Piyushi calls out from the dining table, pointing to the neatly laid out alcohol bottles. Paathik and Yuvraj walk over to get themselves a fresh bottle of beer.

Just then a funky tune starts playing, and Manbir excuses himself to answer his phone. When he steps back in from the balcony, everyone seems to be back in their seats. He makes his way to the bean bag lying next to Ghazal and plops himself onto it. "I'm sorry about that, guys," Manbir apologises, "had to take that one as it was about a new project."

"Is it a brand collab or shoot?" Ghazal asks excitedly. "No ya. It was a producer asking me to be the stylist for his new show. But, my last project with him didn't go as planned. So, I'm sceptical," Manbir says in a lacklustre tone. Paathik enquires, "What happened with the last project? Hope he didn't cheat you of your money." "Oh no. Nothing like that. Actually, it was my first big gig as a stylist for a web series. I was really excited, and everything was going well," Manbir reminisces. "But then, one day, the whole thing fell apart due to some scandal involving the lead actress. And just like that, my dream went kaput."

Sighs echo in the room. Elsa almost instantly picks up her phone and starts typing. After a few moments, she looks up and asks Manbir, "Oh! Was it a show called Tango Time?" With a look of surprise, Manbir confirms Elsa's guess. "How do you know about that?" he probes. "Well, I know all about that case. The actress had a tough time, and in fact, her whole career got destroyed because of that scandal."

"That sounds so horrible. What happened to her?" Yuvraj enquires.

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A SHUT DEVICE CATCHES NO SPIES

"She was a model-turned-actress," Elsa pauses as she fishes out a power bank from her handbag, "This lead role in Tango Time was supposed to be her big break. She was really excited about the project, and she even moved into a posh apartment so that she'd be closer to the shooting venue. What she didn't know was that she moved next door to a fan, who was totally crazy about her." "I feel like this is going to be a stalker story," Ghazal guesses. "It is," Elsa remarks, "but he wasn't a physical stalker; he was a digital one. He was such a coward that he didn't have the guts to come face-to-face with her. Instead, he used his knowledge as a software engineer to access her network, hack her device and then spy on her through the webcam on her iMac."

"That's sick!" exclaims Piyushi. "Disgusting," Elsa adds, "It sickens me to my very core when I think about him. One day, when he was watching her from his computer, he saw her getting intimate with a guy. He couldn't stand that his crush was with someone else and wanted to teach her a lesson. He recorded everything that happened between her and the guy. To make it worse, he posted it online just a couple of weeks before her web series' premiere."

"That shocked all of us," Manbir recounts, "from my

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interactions with her, she didn't seem like someone who would do anything for fame, especially to this extent." Elsa confirms, "Oh yes, that's true. She had only done modelling till then, and she got this role without any connections and name dropping. That video was the end of her career." "Yeah, it affected the lives of everyone involved in the project. The industry was quite cruel to her," Manbir remarks.

"That's true of the world, these days," Paathik corrects him, "it's every man, and woman, for themselves. Her story, as horrifying as it is, should teach us a couple of lessons – Firstly, shut down your computer, always, especially for those who use iMac or an all-in-one computer. They have a bad habit of leaving it on for the sake of convenience. I guess she did that too."

He pauses till he gets a confirmation from Elsa and then continues, "In any case, if you can't shut down your device, keep your WiFi and Bluetooth turned off when not in use. You can also cover your webcam and microphone with a clip or sticker and remove it only when they are in use. This will at least stop anyone from digitally getting into your private space. And, of course, a good anti-virus with firewall and defender turned on would have stopped the stalker from accessing her device in the first place."

"I thought that Apple devices don't need any anti-virus," Piyushi wonders. "That's not true," explains Paathik, "I had mentioned this earlier – just like with charging cables, any hardware that runs a software can be hacked." "Oh!" Shrini notes as realisation dawns on him too. "Unfortunately, these cases are, more often than not, skewed towards women, so Elsa, Piyushi and Ghazal,

take extra care."

"I already try my best to," Piyushi states, "but what happened to my friend's brother proved that women aren't always the target."

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LOO-K! THEY COULD BE WATCHING YOU!

"I'm not surprised," states Elsa, "Most people would be shocked to know that men too are victims. After all, they use the internet as much as women do. So, what happened to your friend's brother, Piyushi?"

"This happened a couple of years back," Piyushi replies, "Ayub aspired to be a renowned journalist. He wanted to be a household name, one that was responsible for covering breaking news, unearthing scams, all of it. So, when he started his career, he knew he had to give it his all. Of course, his phone was at the center of his world – he used it to read the news, find out about local stories, look for evidence and even access the DarkNet – all in the hope that he'd get access to some exclusive information, and get promoted." "Oh no!" exclaims Paathik, "The DarkNet is a hotbed for criminal activity. It's like a double-edged sword – where you can get rare information, but more often than not, you return with a downloaded malware."

"I guess that's what happened to Ayub," Piyushi speculates, "because hackers used his camera to film him when he was in the washroom." "What did they want from him?" Yuvraj interjects. "In exchange for not releasing the video, they asked him to speak against the

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society and the country." "That's dangerous! It would have been enough to incite communal disputes. Did he do it?" Yuvraj questions.

"Well," Piyushi continues, "his brother told me that he had no choice. He couldn't let the video get out in public. So, he published what the hackers wanted, and he got called out for invoking anti-nationalism and hurting people's sentiments. Of course, he also lost his job and had to move back to his village." "Just like that, his dream went up in flames," empathises Elsa.

"Let me explain what the DarkNet really is. Imagine the dark alleyways in our city, the ones your mom has asked you to stay away from, especially at night. At the time, we would have wondered why she was being so cautious, but now we understand. It's very easy to lose sight of where you're going or get wrongly accused. That's what happens when you access the DarkNet. You're bound to get into trouble by just being there." Paathik asserts. "If absolutely needed," Paathik suggests, "I'd recommend taking screenshots or screen recordings instead of downloading anything. This didn't just happen because he downloaded content from the DarkNet, but it took this turn because of his bad habit. He took his phone with him to the washroom. What's scary is that it's a common habit."

"That's true," Yuvraj agrees, "but I, for one, don't understand why. Are we so addicted to our phones that we need them to follow us wherever we go? What will happen if we don't have our phones with us in the washroom?" Elsa agrees, saying, "This is just like any other addiction. It needs to be taken seriously." "With phones having every aspect of our lives in it, I doubt

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people are going to stop this habit," Paathik acknowledges, "so there are still some precautions that they can take. For one, if you really need to take your phone everywhere, you go, at least cover the front and back camera with a clip or a sticker. Or else, keep it in a position where either of the cameras doesn't face you. If any of you guys have this bad habit, I hope this story makes you stop."

"I have to tell my brother about this story," Manbir makes a mental note, "he has a habit of playing Scrabble in the washroom." "I learnt my lesson the really hard way today," Piyushi admits, "when I took the phone into the washroom by mistake." "I used to take my phone to the washroom to listen to music too," Ghazal confesses, "but then I stumbled on a waterproof Bluetooth speaker, which serves the same purpose."

"See, that's smart," Paathik comments, "I like that you found an alternative that won't put you in a compromising position. People don't realise that even though technology has simplified our lives so much, it comes with major privacy issues." "Online privacy," Elsa smirks, "I think this party will never end if we get into that topic."

As she picks up the snack tray for a refill, Piyushi looks around the room and asks, "Anyone feeling hungry? We can order some pizzas if you all are fine with that." A discussion ensues, with everyone calling out their preference, "Margherita." "Thin crust." "No pineapples on my pizza for sure!" "Anything with chicken for me."

After everyone's requests, Elsa remarks, "Let's decide where we are ordering from first. I saw quite a quaint pizza parlour before turning into your lane. Is it any good, Piyushi?" "Oh, it's quite nice," she remarks, "I've tried

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their pizza at my neighbour's place, but I don't think they have online ordering. Can someone try to get their number from Google?"

"Don't only check Google," Shrini warns, "See if you can get the number from your neighbour. After what I once went through, I always verify the phone numbers that I find on Google."

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JUST DON'T GOOGLE IT!

While Piyushi leaves and goes to her neighbour's place, Yuvraj asks, "Tell us what happened to you, Shrini." "Well, I was chilling at my friend Karan's place one weekend, and we wanted to toast to his promotion. We had to place an order with a local wine shop, so without thinking, we got the number from Google, and my friend called them. After taking down the order, they insisted that he make an online payment before delivery. He thought it was mandatory because it was a hefty bill, and he gave his card details for the payment. Instead of Rs.3,500 (USD 46), Rs.35,000 (USD460) got debited from his account."

Manbir winces, "He shouldn't have given his card details on the phone." Nodding, Shrini goes on, "Yea, I know. I would have stopped him, but none of us knew about it because he was making the call from another room. Anyway, Karan called them back; they said it was a mistake and will initiate a refund. So, considering he was dealing with a local shop, he didn't think twice and didn't even tell us about it. He wanted to ask about the order an hour later and saw two more debits of Rs.40,000 (USD 535) and Rs.50,000 (USD 668). That's the time he told us the story. We all tried calling the number, and I got through, but once they realised that we were all calling for the same case, they immediately disconnected.

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Then they just stopped answering all our calls.”

"You should have gone to the shop directly and demanded a refund from them," Elsa asserts. "That's exactly what we did," Shrini declares, "but they said that they never received any order. Then the salesman told us that the same thing happened with other customers – we had been scammed."

"But how?" Elsa asks, "Wasn't it them who took down the card details?" "It wasn't," Shrini sighs, "the shop owner never registered on Google, so Karan had called the wrong number and shared his card details." "This isn't the first time I'm hearing this story," Paathik voices, "I've heard versions of it from many people. In fact, it peaked during the coronavirus lockdown, when the wine shops opened for delivery. Even the veteran actress, Shabana Azmi, was in the news for losing about Rs. 60,000 (USD 800). Some victims got scammed like your friend, and some had the presence of mind not to share their details. In fact, someone I know narrowly escaped being a victim of this scam. But unlike what happened with Karan, my friend was sent a message with the payment link. Only because of his phone's low battery he didn't make the payment immediately. It gave him time to think, which made him realise that the amount they were asking for was far too low for the order he had placed."

"Sharing your card details with anyone over a call can be very dangerous," Elsa adds, "But the bigger issue here is that Google has made our life so simple and easy that we blindly trust any information we find there." Pointing at Shrini, Paathik says confidently, "If your friend scrolled down to read the reviews on Google, he would have been warned. Rather than trusting what's on a search engine,

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it's better to make sure that the number is verified. Either get the number from the restaurant directly or, like Shrini pointed out earlier, get it from someone who has ordered from there."

"There are apps that can help too," Yuvraj suggests, "These anti-threat detecting apps will warn you in case a number has been reported by others as fraudulent." "If we knew what he was going to do," Shrini recounts, "we would have told him to insist on making the payment on delivery instead."

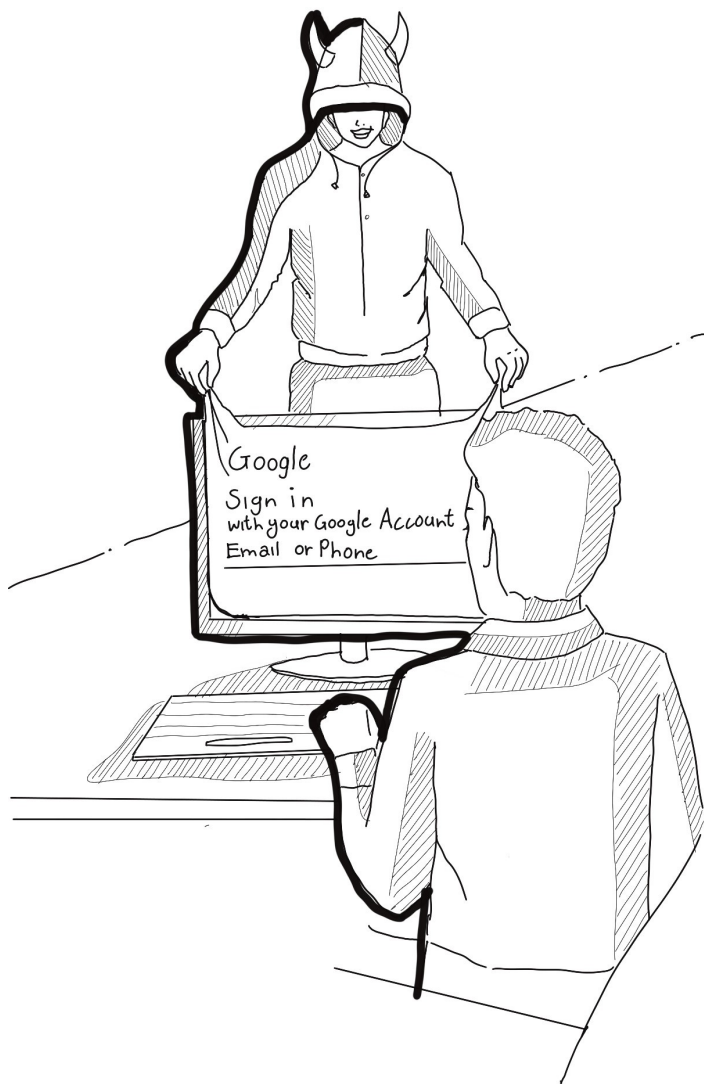
Paathik asserts, "That would have been the best. But what did Karan do when you guys found out? Did he inform his bank and block the card?" With a bob of his head, Shrini shares, "We made him do that even before we visited the shop. Who knew if more money would have been debited? Karan even filed a police complaint." "That's good," Paathik acknowledges, "and it's possible to also claim for recovery of the money under insurance. But that's subject to the service provider's terms and policy and if he has a voice recording. And just to warn others, as you did here, leave a review against that number." "Oh, we all did that," Shrini confirms, "the number isn't there on Google anymore."

"Man, Google has a lot of power over us!" Manbir laments, as Piyushi comes back with the phone number, "We run to the search engine for any small and silly question. Our mails, our photos are other data are also lying with them. It's scary when you can lose it all in a matter of seconds." "But how can you lose your Google data?" Piyushi questions. "Let me tell you about what happened to someone I met at an event," Manbir narrates.

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DUPLICATES CAN DUPE YOU

“This guy lost access to his entire Google account,” Manbir stresses, “mails, photos, videos, notes, documents, contacts, everything.” “Oh, no!” Ghazal empathises, “how did that happen?”

“Well, he’s a scriptwriter who was also trying his luck at stand-up comedy. He would regularly perform at open mics and events. One day it seems he received a mail from a production house asking him to share his pitch for a new comedy show. You can imagine his excitement - that was his dream! He immediately clicked on the link to see what information he needed to fill. He was redirected to the Google login page, where he entered his details. But that one login cost him a lot. The page that he logged in to was a replica of the Google login page.”

“Yes, it’s called website or webpage spoofing,” Paathik interrupts, “By logging in there, he had shared his Google password with the fraudsters.” Manbir continues, “And the password was immediately changed. He couldn’t get back in.”

“I can’t imagine losing all of that, especially my pictures and videos,” Piyushi says in shock, “I have a lot of product shots for Erus that’s stored on Drive. Paathik, would two-factor authentication have helped in this

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case?" "Definitely," Paathik replies, "It would have alerted him when they tried to change his password. But his experience should teach everyone some essential things – One, be especially attentive on pages where you need to enter your password – always check the URL beforehand to know it's a secure site. Make sure you only enter personal details on an HTTPS site, never an HTTP site." "I've heard this too, but what's the difference?" Shrini enquires. Paathik explains, "The only difference between them is that HTTPS uses TLS (SSL) to encrypt normal HTTP requests and responses. To put it in simpler terms, HTTPS is HTTP with encryption."

"Another thing, if the link seems suspicious, search for the web address – in most cases, you will get to see the reviews of a fraud. And lastly, do not click on links in the email directly. Type it into your browser instead. You need to be careful about email attachments, too, especially those that are zipped, because they can contain malicious files. I've even made it a habit for my wife to always scan a zipped file before unzipping it."

"Not just downloaded documents," Yuvraj cautions, "we must scan anything new before you save it on your device. Especially when these are external storage devices like a USB or hard disk." He continues, "I know of a newbie player who lost all of his data when he connected a small pen drive."

"Oh, that's scary," Elsa utters.

Before Yuvraj begins, Piyushi interrupts, "Guys, I got the number of the pizza place from my neighbour," Piyushi announces with glee. "Anyone wants to change their order, or should I go ahead?" After everyone's

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affirmation, Piyushi requests Shrini to place the order. As Shrini picks up his phone and heads to the balcony, he remarks, “Don’t start that story just yet. I want to know what happens.”

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QUIT PLAYING GAMES WITH YOUR DEVICES

Shrini re-enters the living room, and as he makes his way back to his chair, he declares, "The order is placed! Thanks for waiting, guys."

With an acknowledging nod, Yuvraj begins, "Rakesh was getting ready to participate in an online gaming tournament, but a few days before, his graphics card crashed. He didn't want to lose a chance to participate, so he bought a new graphics card." With a sigh, he continues, "Sadly, while he was participating in the competition, his system stopped because his new graphics card also crashed."

"Poor guy," says Piyushi, "I can totally relate to that." "Yeah," continues Yuvraj, "he had to forfeit his place in the competition, but he lost more than that. He called his regular IT guy, who had to sanitise his device. He lost a lot of his data too."

"But what was the issue?" Manbir asks. "Well, the IT guy said that it was used in a DDoS attack. His system was deeply infected. After the first graphics card crashed, he didn't realise that his hard disk was also infected, which caused the new graphics card to crash too. He poked around and discovered that Rakesh had used a pen drive that he got from his local xerox shop." "Wait, so

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what exactly is a DDoS attack?” questions Ghazal.

“Let me take that,” explains Paathik, “What would have happened is that the infection allowed his computer and resources to be used as part of multiple compromised computer systems, to create an unexpected traffic jam and restrict regular traffic. His system was now being used as a mule to conduct DDoS attacks on other machines. That caused his system’s resources to be drained beyond their power, causing the graphics card to crash.” After a quick pause to take a sip, Paathik continues, “In fact, a startup client of mine lost 6 months of launch time in the market along with their reputation because one of his competitors hired organised DDoS attackers from Eastern Europe to conduct heavy DDoS attacks each time my client tried to launch their website. You would be surprised to know that this is so simple that one can buy this service like a transaction on Amazon.”

“But his biggest mistake,” Paathik continues, “was that he didn’t scan the external device before using it. I know most people don’t scan the USB drive as they believe it takes time, but try a quick scan and see. It doesn’t really take that much time. The ones that are used in a xerox shop are being plugged into multiple devices, and you never know what’s being transferred onto it.”

“An anti-virus, firewall and defender would have also helped,” adds Elsa. With a nod, Paathik continues, “His other error was that he didn’t sanitise his entire device before inserting the new graphics card. Had he done that, the malware would have been killed, and his competition wouldn’t have been interrupted.”

“Paathik, you seem to know a lot about technology,” Ghazal observes. “Arre, he’s a whiz when it comes to

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software and hardware too," Yuvraj broadcasts, "after all, he spent years in the industry before becoming a cybercrime lawyer." "23 long years of delivering unique solutions to the world," Paathik confirms, "but getting back to the point of DDoS attacks – it's very common amongst gamers since they use powerful machines. The specialised malware hunts for these machines to use them as mules to prey on other systems."

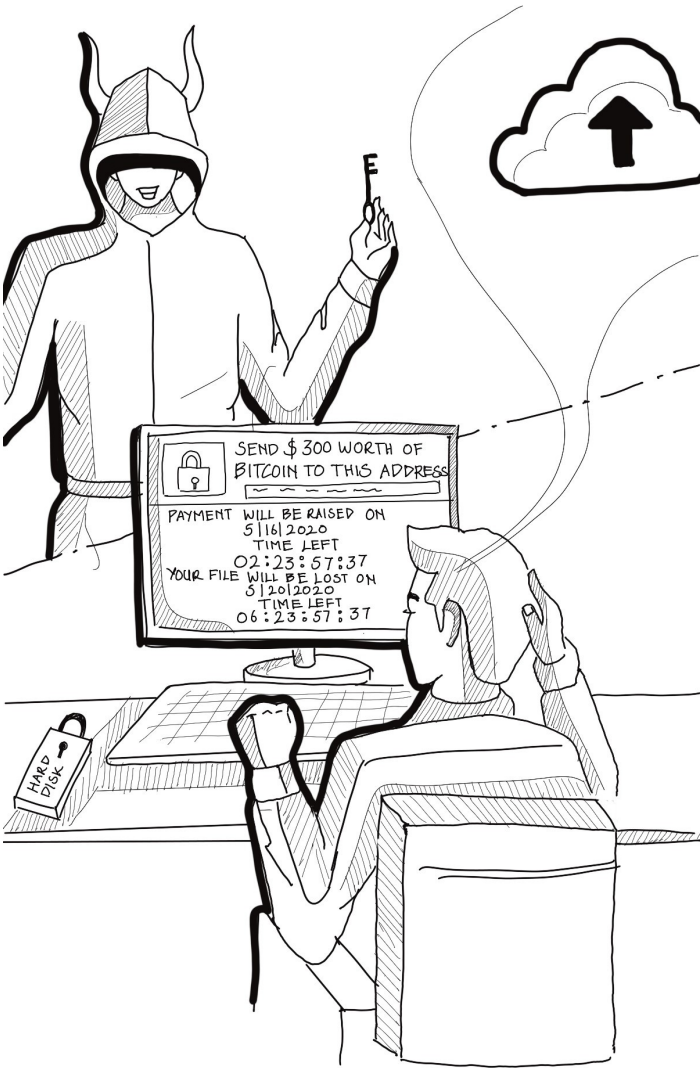
"Well, this is one less issue that I have to be worried about," says Ghazal, "I'm using a company laptop, and the USB ports are disabled." "Yes, a lot of companies do that," Paathik acknowledges, "And while that's done to avoid any leak of sensitive information, it's also done so that the system isn't compromised." "Yeah, we had a huge seminar on cyber safety last year, but it was so boring," Ghazal fakes a yawn. Everyone chuckles and Ghazal continues, "Wish you had taken that session. It would have been so much more interesting."

Paathik takes a bow, saying, "Thank you, but that's the power of a good story!"

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IT'S COOL TO BE ON THE CLOUD

“Talking about a good story, I have one!” announces Shrini, "In fact, it's a bit similar to Yuvraj's story, and it happened to a guy in my building."

Just then, Ghazal lets out an "Oops!" as a wad of dip falls on her kurta. Elsa pulls out a few tissues from the box on the table and hands them to Ghazal. She, in turn, apologises, "I'm sorry, yaar, but I'll just need a minute to clean up."

When she returns, Shrini continues, "So, this guy Aryan started his career in an events management company, and after a couple of years, gained the confidence to build his own setup. His company was doing really well. He was winning more projects, and the strength of his company continued to grow. He always credited that to the library of work that he had created – with different stall designs, themes, artwork, setups, etc. It served as a base for every new project. A couple of years back, he became a victim of a ransomware attack."

"2017, right?" Paathik asks. When Shrini confirms, he says, "There was a surge of ransomware attacks that year, which infected millions of devices across the globe." "What's a ransomware attack?" asks Piyushi. "It's basically a type of malware that encrypts a victim's files,

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and only on paying a ransom will the files be restored," Paathik explains. "Yes, that's what happened with Aryan," Shrini confirms, "He was asked to pay USD 300 worth of Bitcoin as ransom." "Oh! Just like ransom in the real world," Piyushi interrupts, before Shrini continues, "Before making a decision, he checked his backed-up data – but unfortunately, his hard disk was also infected."

"So, did he pay up?" Manbir enquires. "He contemplated not paying the ransom, but that would mean that the library he had built for his company would be gone. Reproducing it would take years, and would cost lakhs, so he paid up the ransom to get his files back."

"He's lucky that he got his files back. Not every hacker would have released the files even after getting the money," Paathik informs, "It's good he took a backup. But the ransomware can actually travel to different machines on a network and encrypt all the data." "So, if the hard disk was fine, would he have saved the USD 300?" asks Elsa. "Yes, had the hard disk not been infected, it would have had his files. But unfortunately, he connected it to his infected laptop, and the ransomware got transferred. This could have easily been avoided if he had specifically invested in anti-ransomware tools. These are sold as additional packages primarily to protect such libraries of work."

"That's one reason why I save all my data on iCloud," Yuvraj states, "I've found it to be more secure. Am I right, Paathik?" He gets a thumbs up from the cyber expert, who adds, "Not only iCloud, but even Google Drive is known for its security. They actually scan every file that's uploaded, and there are better security

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parameters in place than what any anti-virus or other application can offer."

Paathik takes a sip of his beer before continuing, "However, with some of us, the issue is that we're very lax about taking a backup in the first place." "Oh, we heard about that during the seminar too," Ghazal notes, "and since then, we've been following the practice of taking a backup every 30 days. In fact, the photos and videos from my phone are also backed up on Google."

"Piyushi would need to buy extra space every month just to store her selfies," Shrini teases. "Oh please!" she laughs and quickly adds, "But since you brought it up, I was thinking we should take some pictures tonight." "Let's do it, yaar," Manbir says, as he fishes out his phone from his pocket. Just then, the doorbell rings. "That's got to be the pizza!" Piyushi cheers and walks to her bedroom to get her wallet.

Shrini and Paathik head over to the door to help Piyushi with the dinner. "You got the card machine?" she asks the delivery boy as she fishes for her card. He quickly takes her card, dips it into the machine, and turns it to Piyushi for the PIN. While confirming that everyone's pizza has arrived, Piyushi goes to enter the PIN. Paathik instantly covers the keypad with his free hand and turns his head away as Piyushi enters the PIN.

After she closes the door, Piyushi remarks, "Thanks, Paathik. I was distracted and didn't realise what I was doing." "That silly mistake could have cost you a lot, literally!" Paathik cautions as they walk to their back to their seats, "So many people have lost so much money because they are careless when making payments."

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“That’s true,” Elsa confirms, “I have a friend who lost Rs.50,000 (USD 670) after swiping her card at a restaurant. We are still trying to figure out what exactly happened.”

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KEEP YOUR FRIENDS CLOSE AND YOUR DEBIT CARD CLOSER

“This happened last week,” Elsa begins as she helps Piyushi pass the plates from the dining table, “My friend got a much-awaited promotion, and she took a group of us out for drinks. When the time came to pay the bill, she handed the card over to the waiter. The next day, I woke up with a panic call from her saying that her account was swiped for nearly Rs.50,000 (USD 670)!”

“What? Rs.50,000?!” exclaims Shrini in disbelief. “Yeah,” confirms Elsa, “she frantically called the bank too, but they confirmed that there didn't seem to be any sign of misuse, especially because she still had her card and hadn't made any big purchase recently.”

“Did she block her card and inform the cops?” asks Yuvraj. “Yes,” Elsa replies, “but I should message her to find out if she's heard back from the cops.” “Did she use a Credit or Debit Card?” Paathik enquires. “Debit,” Elsa confirms. “If she had used a Credit Card, at least the transaction would have been in dispute,” Paathik declares, “It's good that she blocked her card and informed the police. It seems like a case of skimming where your card is cloned.”

“Oh yeah, that happened to someone I know too,” Yuvraj points out, “but more on that later.” “So, how

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exactly are the cards cloned,” asks Elsa trying to piece together what happened to her friend that night. “A small device, called a skimmer,” Paathik explains, “is placed on card readers and are designed in such a way that it’s hidden from plain sight. There are some which are designed to look exactly the same as a card machine. When your card is swiped, it copies your card details.” “Okay,” Elsa comments as she absorbs the new information, “But wouldn’t they have also needed her PIN?”

“Well, he could have seen the PIN if your friend entered it like Piyushi was going to right now,” Paathik says, pointing to the embarrassed host, “but just card details would also suffice for making international payments where the PIN is not required.” “Oh no!” says Elsa, with a worried look on her face, “I’m glad she blocked the card and registered the complaint with the cops.”

“Not to disappoint you,” empathises Paathik, “but from my experience, I don’t think her issue will be resolved.” “But why?” questions Piyushi. Paathik goes on to explain, “Firstly, we all have to admit that our police department has too much on their plate. Although they do their best to catch criminals, the rise in cybercrimes has made their jobs so much more difficult. They are flooded with cases of fraud involving small amounts daily, and they can’t go chasing after every criminal. This is also why hackers and cyber thieves attack people for smaller amounts. Small amounts but in greater numbers is their modus operandi.”

And also, in your friend's case," Paathik turns to Elsa, "because she handed the card over to the waiter, it makes

her case complicated. It's the most dangerous thing you can do. Just to clear my doubts, did he try swiping the card first and then dipped it?"

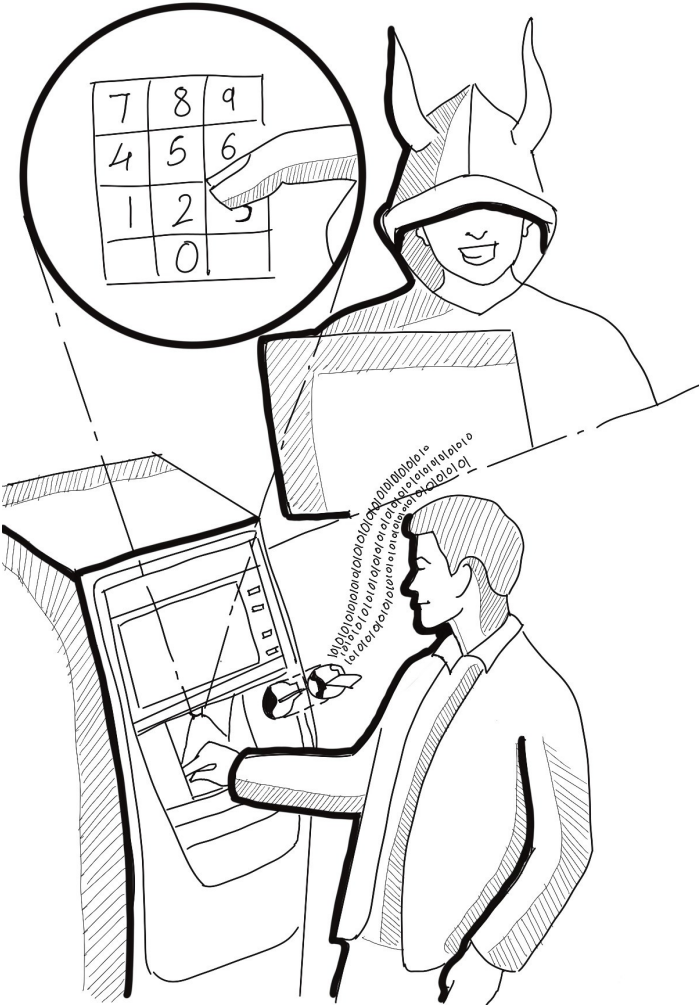
Elsa takes a moment to recollect the events of the night and then replies, "Come to think of it, he did say that there was some issue with the card. But I'm not too sure of the details; we were busy making plans to meet up again." "Aha!" Paathik exclaims, "that's where you guys made a mistake. Never take your eyes away from the card. Even when entering the PIN, keep the keypad covered. If you all were so distracted, I'm sure the waiter saw the PIN entered. Piyushi, let this story be a warning to you."

"My god!" Piyushi swears, "I'm never going to make that mistake again." "It's not only at restaurants," Yuvraj warns, "but also at petrol pumps and ATMs that you need to be careful." "ATMs?" Manbir and Ghazal both exclaim in unison.

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LOOK BEFORE YOU SWIPE

Before he responds, Yuvraj polishes off the last bit of chips from the bowl. “Yes, my neighbour Mohammed lost a good amount of money after he swiped his card at an ATM,” recalls Yuvraj.

With a swig of his beer, he continues, “So, what happened to him was completely out of the blue. He was at a local park when he received two messages back-to-back – both debit messages from his bank – around Rs.20,000 (USD 270) each, if I remember correctly. He quickly checked his wallet, saw that he had his card, and called the bank. They validated the transactions and claimed that it had been done with his card and PIN itself, leaving him quite baffled.”

“So, his card was skimmed at an ATM?” asks Manbir. “Yes,” Yuvraj responds, “that’s when I put him in touch with,” he smiles as he points to Paathik, “our resident cyber expert, who was kind enough to take up the case.”

“So, these skimming devices are placed inside ATMs too?” asks Piyushi innocently. “That’s right,” confirms Paathik. They use the skimmer to copy the card details and add a tiny camera facing the keypad, which records the PIN. Sometimes, they also tinker with the keypad to find out which numbers were pressed.” “So, did

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Mohammed recover his money?" Elsa asks.

"Yeah," nods Paathik, "we had to follow up quite a bit, but it thankfully all paid off." "These guys went through a lot of trouble actually," Yuvraj reveals, "They visited the ATM and found that it had been tampered with. They even registered a police complaint to get the CCTV footage. That's where they saw a suspicious- looking man who entered while the guard wasn't there. He was wearing a cap and had covered his face too. Thankfully, that was enough for the bank to reverse the amount debited."

"In this case, though, wasn't Mohammed was completely innocent?" asks Manbir, "I mean, how could he have known that there was a skimmer and camera?" "Well, he technically didn't do anything wrong," replies Paathik, "but there are a couple of things he could have done to make sure that he was safe. You guys better make a note too. First of all, be observant. Check the ATM keypad and insert slot. If there's a skimmer placed, it will look bulkier than usual. Check for any glue/residue on any part of the ATM and shake the slot to check for loosely fitted attachments. Then check for any hidden cameras that could be facing the keypad. These are sometimes hard to find, so it's better to cover the keypad when you type in your PIN."

"I press random numbers on the keypad," Shrini discloses. "That's good," Paathik remarks, "you can also wipe the keypad with a handkerchief. These things need to be done at every ATM, especially at the ones without security guards. But if you suspect something like this, you must block your card first so that it's not misused further. Just remember one thing, though - when it comes

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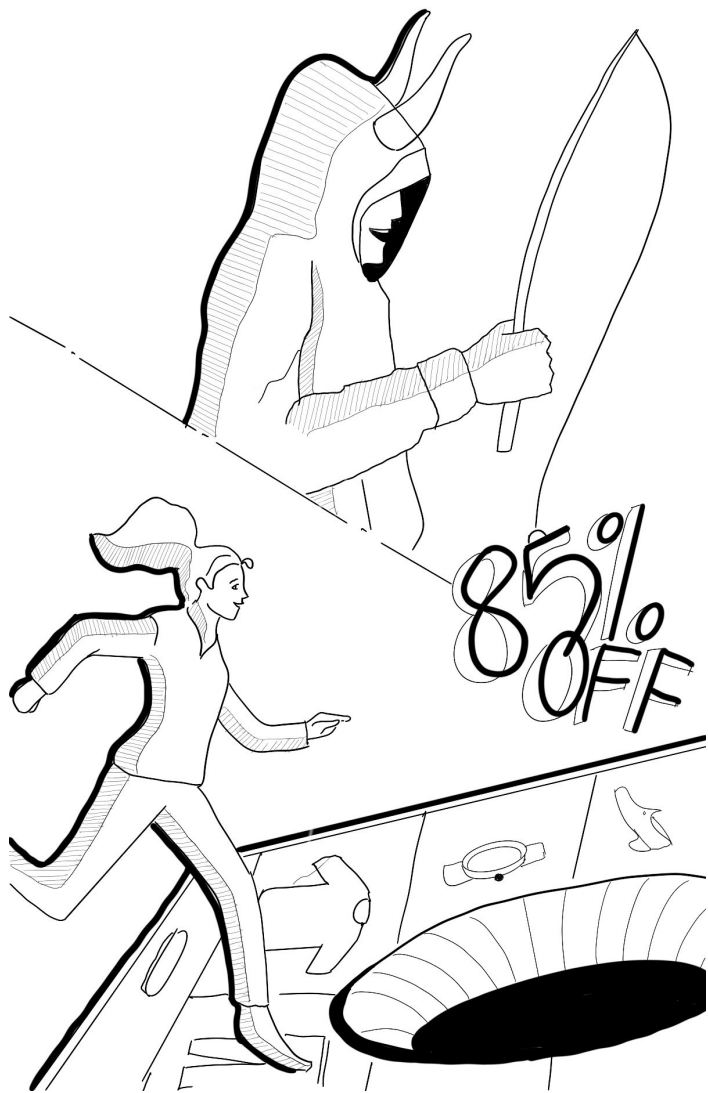
to this kind of a situation where the bank's property is compromised, they are liable to pay you back every penny. With investigations and all, it may take some time to get your money back, but it's worth the wait.” “People wait for days for their shopping orders,” Elsa comments, “so no one should complain about this.” “Speaking of shopping online,” Paathik interrupts, “I’ve got a story that’s a hot topic for bargain hunters.”

“These stories sure are sizzling hot,” Piyushi cuts in, “but our pizzas are getting cold. Dig in, please!” “I’ve been happily helping myself all this time while you guys have been so engrossed,” Manbir says with a broad grin. They each reach for a slice, and with a smile, Piyushi requests, “Sorry to interrupt you, Paathik. Go on.”

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PAYING THE PRICE OF RECKLESS ONLINE SHOPPING

“Let me tell you about this girl, Nisha, who I met at my co-working space,” Paathik begins, “She saw a great online deal on some branded products – 85% discount, is what she said.” “I’m sure that came with T&Cs,” laments Ghazal.

“It came with a lot more,” replies Paathik, “but she was too excited about the once-in-a-lifetime offer that she was getting, and she added a LOT of items to her cart – shoes, accessories, jackets, jewellery, handbags, the list went on. While she wasn’t familiar with the website, she knew all the brands it showcased, so she didn’t think twice. Her order was delivered in about a week, as promised, but she was shocked when she opened the box to only find a piece of cloth in it!”

“Ouch! What did she do?” Elsa asks. “Well, she wanted to complain and demand a refund, but she didn’t know where to do it! She had seen an ad on Facebook or Instagram and had immediately clicked through and made the purchase. She lost about Rs.25,000 (USD 340) to this scam, and all because of that impulsive purchase.”

“But why would they send her anything if they already had her money?” Elsa asks curiously. “Well, that’s because when a chargeback is raised as part of a

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dispute with the credit card company, the scamsters can use this to prove that they delivered the order.”

“I’ve seen deals like these online too,” Piyushi confirms, “from random stores, but because I’ve never heard about them, I’m quite wary about buying anything from there. As a practice, I only order from these unknown stores if any of my friends have ordered and verified that the brand is fine.” “That’s the right way to do it,” Paathik confirms, “It’s best to shop from trusted websites and ignore the stores/brands that you’ve never heard of, especially when they advertise offers that are too good to be true. I mean, think about it, the price of high- end branded products won’t have such an extreme discount. If they don’t offer the discount themselves, how can anyone else afford to?”

“But, Paathik,” Manbir interrupts, “there are so many new brands these days. So even if I’ve not heard about it, it could be a legitimate brand with good products, right?” “Yeah,” Piyushi interjects, “that’s like mine. Not too many people know about it yet.” “There are a lot of brands like yours, Piyushi, that are popping up every other day,” Paathik clarifies, “But there are simple things that you need to check before swiping your card on any site. Firstly, check the website – does it look sharp and clean? Are there any glaring language mistakes? A legitimate brand would never make typos on their website.”

“You won’t find that kind of mistakes of my website,” claims Piyushi, “I hired professional to create it, and personally checked every word.” “See,” Paathik remarks, “when someone puts in that effort and bears that cost, then you know they’re legit and in it for the long run. Secondly, you need to look for reviews, not on their

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website, but on Google and other sites. Recent positive reviews could be planted as well, so dig deeper and check for any older low-rating reviews. If the website is new, check if it has been covered by any popular media – if the brand is offering something good, there will be good press about it on other sites.” “These days, even digital publications are far too many,” Ghazal informs, “and with them come a lot of fake news and reviews – all to make a quick buck. I’d suggest that you stick to the established publications.”

“That’s a good point,” Paathik admits before getting back to his list, “You should then check the company’s return policy. If it’s non-existent, there’s your red flag! Also, most dealers are already registered on e-commerce sites like Amazon – so cross-check the products and the discounts offered. Lastly, see if the brand has a registered address and a contact number. No contact details; no swiping your card! If Nisha had done any of this, it would have saved her Rs.25,000!”

“Rs.25,000,” Ghazal echoes, “That’s a lot of money to get duped of.” “She was lucky that it was just her money that went,” Paathik cautions, “A lot of these scams are also to build a comprehensive digital profile of people. After all, you’re sharing your name, address, contact details, and even card details. This information can easily fetch scamsters a lot of moolah in the international cyber market.”

“Come to think of it,” Shrini realises, “creating a website is quite easy these days. There are DIY themes, and with very little knowledge about building websites, people can set it up. Doesn’t need a big investment too.” “That’s true. A lot of people suggested that I do that for

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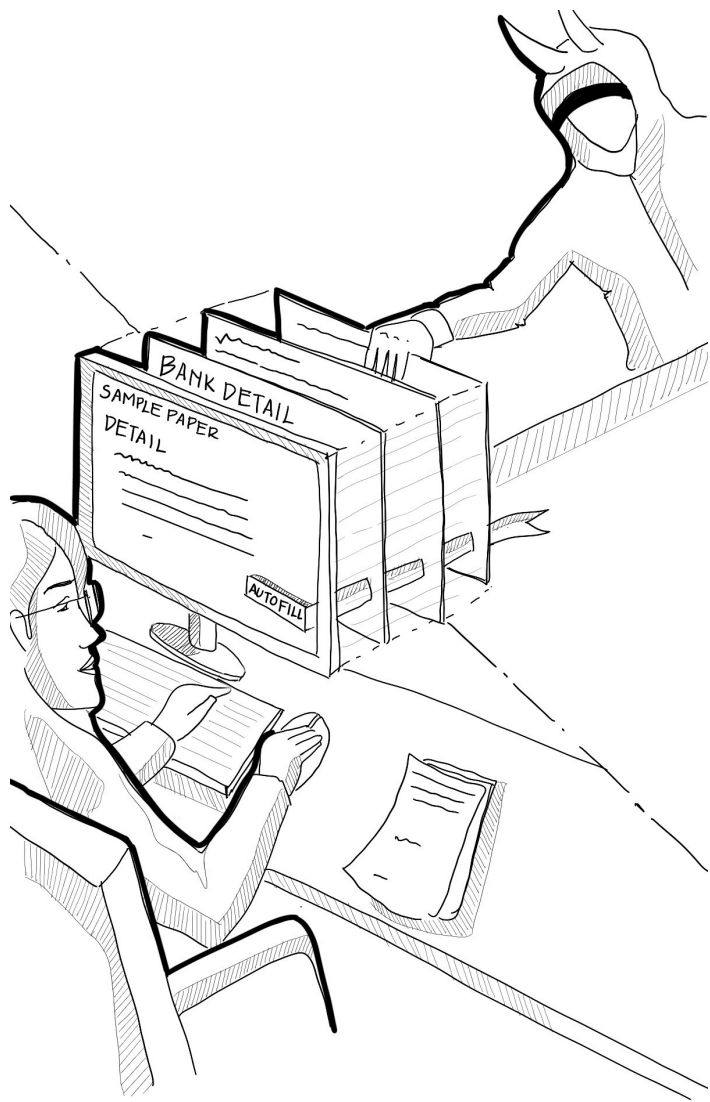
my website,” Piyushi discloses, “but I wanted to get it done right the first time.” “Yeah, it’s also a matter of convenience these days,” remarks Yuvraj, “that’s the need of the hour, and even the reason why we save all our details on shopping sites.”

“Our habits go far beyond that, unfortunately,” sighs Piyushi, “I know someone who saved all her details on the browser and ended up losing money too.”

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WHEN AUTOFILL LEADS TO AN AUTO DEBIT

"Man, so many people are losing money online," Ghazal laments, "it's scary to even think about it happening to me." Glancing at the shocked and despondent faces around, Manbir says in an uplifting tone, "Guys, it looks like we need a refill. Bottoms up, everyone!"

After they all settle back down, Paathik urges Piyushi to begin her story, "What were you saying about savings details on a browser?"

"Oh yes!" Piyushi recounts, "Well, my friend's sister, Ankita, fell prey to one of these scam websites when she was preparing for her 12th Boards. She's the kind of student who likes to be fully prepared. Even though her school gave her past practice papers, she would look for more papers online." "I wish I had that much dedication during my exams, man," Paathik says with a laugh, "The study material is more than enough for me."

"I don't even get through them," adds Piyushi, "So anyway, most of these sites ask for details like name and email ID before allowing access to their files. She immediately submitted those details, but the webpage didn't open. She closed the website and continued her search for more papers. But later, when her dad's account

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was debited some Rs.50,000 (USD 670), he started an investigation and found out that it was Ankita's visit to that website that caused it." "What?" asks Elsa, "she didn't enter any card details, did she?"

"Well, she didn't enter any card details on that website," Piyushi confirms, "but when she filled in the form, she used autofill, which gave the website access to all her saved data, including her dad's card details." "I thought autofill only picked out data for that particular field," Yuvraj comments. "Well, it does, but to do that, it accesses all the data you've saved," informs Paathik, "It's best to disable the autofill feature and type out your details each time."

"Oh god!" Ghazal gulps, "I have my details saved on autofill too!" "There's no harm to do it on trusted websites," Paathik pacifies, "but I hope you've not saved sensitive information like bank and card details on autofill. Of course, that doesn't mean that your email ID and phone number can be shared on any website. Ensure that it's legit – read their privacy policy before giving your details to them. And most importantly, check the URL. Remember I told you guys about HTTP vs HTTPS? It applies here too."

"All this information is quite beneficial, Paathik," Shrini comments, "Have you ever thought about writing a book on this topic? I mean, you'd help so many people from losing their money." Paathik nods with a knowing smile, but Yuvraj interrupts, "That's a good idea. Till now, Paathik has been helping those who've already lost their money and with a book he can help them before they lose it."

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Addressing Piyushi, Manbir comments, "You told us about your friend's sister saving her personal and card details on the browser. I know of a friend who saved his passwords too!" "Sorry to interrupt, but this beer is making me want to use the washroom," Elsa says as she gets up from the sofa. "It's the first door on the right, Elsa," Piyushi directs. "I need a smoke break too," Paathik says, taking out the smokes and lighter, "Piyushi, is it okay if I light one in the balcony?" "Sure," Piyushi confirms, "you'll find an ashtray there too." "I'll join you," Manbir quickly says as he gets up to follow Paathik.

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IS SAVING PASSWORDS ON A BROWSER REALLY SAFE?

The balcony doors open, and as Paathik and Manbir walk back into the sitting area, Shrini calls out, “Just the man we’ve been waiting for, Manbir. You left us hanging.”

Manbir finds his favourite spot empty and makes himself comfortable on the bean bag. “Okay, Manbir is back with another story for his lovely audience,” Manbir jokes, pretending to hold a mic. “Are we getting a sneak peek into your next show, Manbir?” Paathik asks playfully. Laughing it off, Manbir continues, “This happened to a friend of mine, Angad, who works at a radio station. In our group, he's known as the 'busy body'– he's always on the phone, or checking emails or attending meetings. Even if he were here right now, he'd be too busy even to tell this story.” “All work and no play....” Piyushi starts and is quickly interrupted by Manbir, who completes her sentence, “cost Angad a lot of money.”

With everyone listening intently, Manbir goes on, “He has a habit of downloading music, images, dialogues and all from different websites. And these days, because everyone wants your data, they ask you to register on the site. Angad had done that on so many sites, and to make it easier for him, he used the same password everywhere

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and let his browser save it for him. One day, when we were hanging out together, he got an email from an unknown sender. He was shocked to read that this person knew the password to all his accounts – including Facebook, LinkedIn and his email.”

“Oh no!” Ghazal gasps. With an acknowledging nod, Manbir goes on, “He couldn’t believe it, so he tried logging into the accounts, only to find himself locked out. The hacker warned him against reporting it to the individual platforms, with a threat of making his personal life extremely public. The hacker went so far as to mention that even the cops won’t be able to trace him.”

Shocked, Shrini asked, “What did the hacker want?” “Money,” he replied calmly, “what everyone wants. He asked Angad to make a USD 200 payment through Bitcoin within 24 hours, and only then he would release his accounts.” Almost at the edge of her seat, Ghazal asks, “So did he do it? Did he make the payment?” With a nod, Manbir replies, “Of course. He immediately made the payment. He had no time to lose, and he didn’t find the amount to be a big blow.”

“Big amount or not, I’d freak out if anyone had access to my accounts – my email especially,” Shrini points out, as Piyushi excuses herself and makes her way to the kitchen. “He’s lucky that it was only USD 200, but I’m sure he learnt his lesson,” Paathik states as Piyushi returns with ice for Shrini’s drink, “It’s foolish to save passwords on the browser. In fact, he shouldn’t be downloading anything from untrusted websites too. We know what happened to Manbir’s scriptwriter friend. Giving cookie access to these websites is also a big no. Software should only be downloaded from the developer’s website.” “But

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his job requires him to download all of this,” Manbir says in his friend’s defence, “he really can’t help it.”

“Then his anti-virus should be equipped with web browser security so that it can warn him of suspicious websites,” Paathik points out, “Browser hacking is so easy these days. I’ll let you guys in on what I do – create a separate email ID and don’t use that password anywhere else. Then use this email ID for any random registration.”

“That’s quite useful,” Ghazal states, “especially since there are so many random browsers with different claims. In fact, someone I worked with used a random browser because he claimed that it was faster. One ad he clicked on by mistake, and that was it. The fraudster had access to his computer and even recorded the screen when he was getting intimate with his girlfriend on a video call. The guy had to pay up around Rs.50,000 (USD 670), I think.”

“Similar issue,” Paathik agrees, “you can’t trust any browser. You need to ensure your online safety. These random browsers,” he said, making air quotations, “are simply too good to be true. There’s a reason why Safari and Chrome are popular – they are both more established. As a matter of fact, Chrome’s Safe Browsing Mode is enabled by default. Moreover,” he pauses and turns to Ghazal, “this guy went a step ahead and clicked on an ad by mistake, making it even worse. I’m sure he didn’t have any anti-virus on his device. When he clicked that ad, malware, which is commonly known as Adware, would have been downloaded on his computer. That’s why I’d recommend buying a good anti-virus with web browser security, which would have picked that up in the weekly scan – though I’d suggest a scan every three days. I know it might sound paranoid, but trust me, I know exactly

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what's out there to harm us.”

"Guys, I don't know about you all, but these stories are making me rethink everything I do," Shrini worries. Ghazal, from the other side of the room, gestures to him, saying, "Then you're not going to like the story I have to tell you about how a seemingly helpful app caused someone to lose a lot of money." "More money scams?" Piyushi sighs, "Paathik, it looks like you've opened Pandora's box."

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PASSWORD MANAGER TURNS DAMAGER

"Paathik, before you hear this story and tell me what my friend did was wrong," Ghazal starts, "let me say it – she used a password manager app." Paathik winces but gestures at her to keep going. "It was completely out of the blue when Roop received a debit message of Rs.1 lakh (USD 1,350) from her bank," Ghazal narrates, leaving everyone stunned, "She immediately looked into her wallet and found that the Debit Card was still with her. She hadn't even visited an ATM in the past couple of days. She called her bank right away to report the transaction and was shocked to find out that the transaction was done through internet banking with her login details, so the bank could not reverse the transaction. What we later came to understand was that the hacker got her login details from the password manager app."

"I've seen this happen before," Paathik affirms, "let me explain what happened behind the scenes." Turning to Ghazal, he goes on, "I'm guessing she used a free app." After an acknowledgement from her, he continues, "Since it's free to use, these apps need to find other profitable sources. And you'd be surprised to know how much they earn by selling credible data profiles of people. I already

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told you how valuable your information is. The scamsters had access to everything they needed – bank account login details to initiate the transfer and email credentials to intercept the OTP." Ghazal cut him off, saying, "Yes, she did find out that the OTP was sent to her email instead of her phone."

Piyushi, who was till now listening intently, says, "To be frank, until Paathik told us about his story method, it's been difficult for me to remember multiple passwords. Even so, I've never considered using a password manager app, but I would think that a password app would be an innovative solution to that." "Let me take this one, Paathik," Elsa suggests, "I've heard complaints about this before, more on that later, but there are paid password manager apps that you can use. It's better to shell out money for something credible than regret it all later."

"That's true, Elsa," Paathik says, giving her a thumbs up, "but there are some things to look out for even before paying for a password manager app, or any app for that matter." As he starts counting on his fingers, Paathik resumes, "One, check the numbers! 3.5 stars or more, with reviews from more than 100 people and at least 1000 downloads, are good starting points."

"I check the reviews before downloading any unknown apps," Yuvraj shares. "Yes, that needs to be done too," Paathik points to him in acknowledgement, "Go through the reviews and read those with low ratings. That's where the real workings of an app lie. Three, if you're not sure about digital security, don't be one of the first to download an app unless, of course, it's from a trustworthy source like Google or Apple. What else?" Paathik pauses to think, "Ah yes, four, make sure that the

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app has been on the store for at least two months, as it would have passed the app store's security standards or gotten enough reviews. And lastly, have a look at the app developer and which other apps they've created. Generally, a good development company will have multiple different apps on the store. If it's ambiguous, it's best to stay away. But as Elsa said, there's nothing better than keeping sensitive information like your passwords right here," Paathik concludes as he taps his temple.

Picking up from where Paathik left off, Elsa lists out, "Phew! So far, we know why we can't share it with anyone, save it on our browsers, or store it in an app. But let me tell you why you shouldn't be noting it down on your phone either."

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SAY NO TO NOTING DOWN PASSWORDS

Shrini's ears perk up. "On your phone too?" he says, "This I need to hear." Elsa starts her story, "It was about a week before my friend, Saisha's wedding, and she wanted one last night with her girls before tying the knot. She gathered her gang – college friends, some colleagues and her cousin, Lea, and went out clubbing. I missed the party because I wasn't in town. Anyway, that night they danced, drank and celebrated Saisha's last few days of singlehood. Everyone was so happy for her, except her cousin, Lea. What no one knew was that she was earlier romantically involved with Saisha's fiancé."

"Ooo! The jealous ex," Manbir says with an evil grin. Elsa continues, "So, what happened was that Lea managed to get a hold of Saisha's phone to click a picture. While she told the girls to stand together and give their best poses, she started rummaging through Saisha's phone. She knew that Saisha had a habit of keeping all her passwords in the notes app. She quickly found it, shared it with herself and then deleted the chat. Poor Saisha was so intoxicated and busy posing that she didn't realise all this happened right in front of her."

"No one in that situation would ever realise," Ghazal related. "Definitely not!" exclaimed Elsa, "And that's what Lea took advantage of. She downloaded some old

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pictures of Saisha with her ex from backup on the cloud and then shared them on Saisha's Facebook account, knowing fully well that Saisha's in-laws were friends with her on the platform. And that was it – they made sure that Saisha didn't marry into their family." "Really?" Piyushi asks in disbelief, "over some old pictures? That's so sad." "Well, it was an arranged marriage," Elsa reveals, "and the family was a bit conservative."

"I don't want to sound insensitive," Paathik proceeds cautiously, "but in this day and age, it's ridiculous to keep sensitive information like your password in a notes app." In support, Elsa says, "I agree she shouldn't have done that, but, sadly, it happened. I tried to reason out with the family to make them see her point of view, but nothing helped."

"In today's age, I've come to realise that being too trusting always works against you," says Paathik, "Saisha blindly trusted her cousin and handed over her unlocked phone. It's just like what happened to Maria when she gave her phone to someone to make a call. You know, there's this one saying in crime: *Most victims know their perpetrators*, which is backed by historical data. So, when I say don't blindly trust anyone when it comes to your digital assets, there's years of data backing that advice."

"Only in this case, instead of installing malware, Lea got access to her passwords," Yuvraj observes. "Yes," Paathik confirms, "and that's because she saved her passwords carelessly. She could have used an app locker, a paid one, of course, and saved herself the trouble."

"Some phones have a hidden space that requires fingerprint authentication," Shrini comments, "I guess that works the same way." Paathik nods, as Ghazal shares,

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"If I had it my way, we would be able to do away with passwords and only use OTPs."

"Be careful what you wish for, Ghazal," Paathik says with a devilish smirk, "have you heard about how common OTP scams are these days? You'll know if you've watched the series, *Jamtara*, about a real place in Jharkhand which is known as the cyber crime capital of India. It details out the working of these OTP scams, and you'll be surprised to know that it's not just limited to SMS, but also targets Whatsapp users as well." "Whatsapp too?" Yuvraj frets. "Unfortunately, yes," Paathik says with a sigh, "what happens is that you get a Whatsapp message from a known friend rushing you to share an OTP that was accidentally sent to your number. When you share this, you've basically given permission for your Whatsapp number to be registered on another phone. Now you're locked out of Whatsapp, and the scamster has access to your entire contact book and continues scamming your friends."

"Oh wow!" Manbir exclaims, "That's some other level, man!" Paathik nods in agreement as a few of the guests get up to wash their hands. Once they're back, Piyushi draws everyone's attention, "Guys, the mood is becoming quite sombre, and before we get engrossed in another story, let's click that selfie that we were supposed to!" Manbir quickly gets up and holds his phone up to get everyone in the frame. The room cheers as they all gather around him to click a picture. As they scroll through what's been clicked, Yuvraj comments, "Oh, that's a nice one – a great memory!" Once he's back in her seat, Ghazal says, "I'll give you my number; send it to me there. You won't be able to tag me on any social

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platforms." "Oh!" Paathik says in surprise, "how come you work in an ad agency, and you're not on social media?"

"I am on social media, but I keep a really, really low profile," Ghazal responds, "as they say once bitten, twice shy." "Did something happen to you?" Elsa says out of concern, "if you don't mind me asking."

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WHO'S IN YOUR SOCIAL CIRCLE?

"Don't judge me for this," Ghazal states before she can tell her story, "It happened back in the day when I was new to the city and didn't know anyone." "Oh, just like me!" Manbir chimes in. With a smile, Ghazal continues, "I had a lot of time to kill and would spend most of my days reading. That's when I started a blog for book reviews. It was exciting because I got to digitally meet a lot of like-minded people. But in the craze of increasing my follower base, I made a mistake. I started accepting anyone and everyone's friend requests – all in the hope that they'd see my blog and increase the views. However, it didn't go as planned. In fact, it almost ruined my life." "Oh!" Piyushi exclaims.

"One morning, I woke up to hundreds of missed calls and messages from friends and parents. It turns out someone tagged me in some explicit pictures on Facebook. They even posted one of my profile pictures along with my phone number. At that moment, I didn't know what to do. I immediately untagged myself, but the calls continued. Everyone was pointing fingers at me, and I didn't even get a chance to explain myself. It was a tough time for my family and me. We all had to change our numbers and lay low."

"Did you report the profile to the cops?" asks Elsa.

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"This was all so new to us," Ghazal replies, "that we didn't even think about approaching the cops." "It's different nowadays," Elsa explains, "this kind of incident should first immediately be reported on Facebook and then to the police authorities."

"It's a good thing that you immediately untagged yourself," Paathik comments, "but I understand why you're laying low on social media now." Ghazal nods saying, "I went through a complete social media detox after this, and now I'm very cautious about my online privacy. I've opted for all notifications on my social accounts, just to be informed of any activity." "That's good," Paathik confirms. "You can also choose who can tag you in pictures," Manbir adds, "I've restricted it to friends only." With a nod, Ghazal says, "I've gone the extra mile and stopped anyone from tagging me online."

"That's smart! You can never be too safe with what you post online," Yuvraj asserts, "A guy in my neighbourhood was kidnapped because of what he posted online." "What? Kidnapped!?" Piyushi exclaims. "Yes," Yuvraj continues, "it's a crazy story! He was the kind of guy who boasted about everything he owned – from his dad's BMW to his new iPhone and Xbox, as well. It turns out a follower got jealous, kidnapped him and asked his family for a ransom of Rs. 10 lakhs (USD 13,300)." "Wow! Did they pay that much money?" Shrini questions. "Yes," Yuvraj replies, "they were well-off, so they didn't have a problem paying the ransom." "I think I read about this story," Elsa interjects, "the kidnappers were caught, right?" Yuvraj confirms, "Yes, they were just a bunch of young boys from his school."

"Oh yea, Yuvraj, I remember us discussing this

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incident," Paathik recalls, "The problem was that this guy was a big show-off. There's absolutely no reason to disclose every aspect of your personal life online. The habit of tagging your location and unknowingly sharing sensitive information about yourself and people in your life has got to stop!"

"I agree," Manbir concurs, "when it comes to my personal life, I restrict my posts to my closest friends." "Even so, I'd say don't flaunt your life to close friends as well," Paathik advises, "jealousy can get the best of most people."

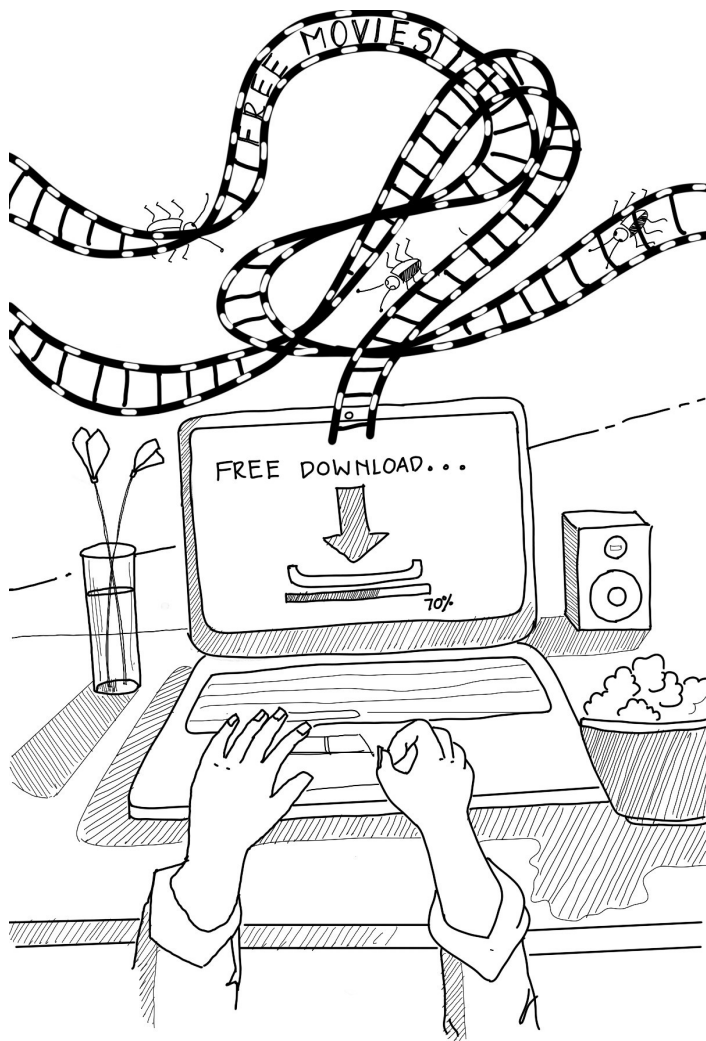
"Guys, let's lighten up the mood with some music," Shrini announces, "anyone has any song requests?" Piyushi hands the Bluetooth speaker to him, but he refuses, saying, "My phone's already connected." "How about some 90s music?" Ghazal suggests. "Got it!" Shrini replies, "let me download a 90s party playlist." After a couple of seconds, he taps his phone and turns to Piyushi, "Hey! Is there an issue with the network in your house?" "Not usually," Piyushi replies. "This feels like I'm *downloading* music in the 90s," Shrini jokes. "Oh god!" Manbir recalls, "I have spent many a sleepless night waiting for movies to download. Thank god, we've advanced to 4G and all now and have OTT platforms to stream movies and shows."

"Net speeds may have improved, but I know people who still download movies using torrents," Yuvraj mentions. "Why would they do that in this day and age? OTT platforms have made it so simple," Elsa expresses. "True," Yuvraj agrees, "but there are so many platforms, and these people don't want to spend on annual subscriptions just for one movie or show."

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THE LATEST BLOCKBUSTER CAN BLOCK YOUR DEVICE

Yuvraj dabs his mouth with a tissue before he begins, “At the time, Rohan was working on his thesis for a doctorate. A couple of days before the submission deadline, he wanted to do a final review. But when he opened the document, all he could see was some gibberish. He tried changing the font. He closed and opened the document again. He even shut down his system a couple of times. But every time he checked, nothing changed. He contacted a friend who worked in IT to help him out. The guy came over to check his machine and found malware installed. While doing a thorough check, he discovered a movies folder and knew that this movie buff had downloaded pirated copies. Rohan confirmed it too.”

“I’m sure it came from there,” Paathik concludes. Yuvraj agrees and continues, “He even tried to help Rohan retrieve his thesis data but was unsuccessful.” “In such cases, taking the laptop to a professional lab for data recovery can be helpful,” Paathik suggests, “but they don’t guarantee full recovery of the data, about 60% is the average. In fact, it also falls quite expensive as they charge by GB.” “That’s a lot,” Elsa expresses.

“Yeah,” Yuvraj confirms, “that’s why the IT guy

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asked Rohan to physically destroy his SSD so that the rest of his data wouldn't get stolen. And that was it – he lost his thesis, didn't get his PhD that year, and also had to invest in a new laptop.”

"Without even asking, I'm sure that he didn't have an anti-virus," Paathik comments, "A complete scan would have detected the issue and dealt with it before it corrupted his thesis. I always fail to understand how people who spend so much money on laptops don't even think about protecting them with an anti-virus. It's almost like buying an expensive car and leaving it in a public parking lot with the keys inside. That's how vulnerable a position they put themselves in."

"Of course, the other fact is that he just shouldn't have downloaded anything from torrents," Yuvraj specifies. "Yeah, that's something we discussed earlier too," Paathik replies, "You can't download anything from random websites. Think about it like this – would you accept free movie tickets from a random person on the street? It's the same with downloading them online. You need to be more cautious about these things. This also goes for random sites that let you stream movies for free too. In fact, I heard a really shocking story about someone who was addicted to blue films.”

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SOMETIMES PLEASURE COMES AT A PRICE

"Let me pour myself another drink first," Paathik announces as he steps towards the dining table. Yuvraj follows him, and Shrini excuses himself and heads to the bathroom.

Once they're back, Paathik raises his glass, "Cheers to this night!" They clink their glasses, and then Paathik continues with his story, "Porn sites are the most common place for hackers to find their targets. And because of the nature of the activity, the victims find themselves extremely vulnerable I heard a story about this guy named Chaitanya from some people in my professional circuit. He was addicted to watching porn movies. He didn't realise that these third-grade websites are usually crammed with viruses. These sites will have multiple pop-up ads, which when clicked will begin to download a malware called Adware which will then gradually start infecting the computer, first by slowing it down. In this case, the malware attached to the virus was programmed to record his every move via the webcam. After many nights of satisfying himself with these movies, he got an email with a link that contained a video of him watching the porno and pleasuring himself. You can imagine how explicit it was."

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"I'm guessing he had to pay a hefty sum to have the video deleted," Shrini speculates. "Not really, "Paathik reveals, "The hacker threatened to publish his video on YouTube in 24 hours. They even claimed they had access to all his contacts, and sent him some samples as proof. Imagine having such a video forwarded to everyone you know. It's so embarrassing! The only thing he could do to stop it was to send the hacker his sister's number and pictures." "Oh! That's terrible," Ghazal says disgustedly, "But from that request, it seems like it was someone who knew him, or at least knew that he had a sister." "It could have been, but it's possible that the hackers also monitored everyone using the device, and hence could have made an assumption, " Paathik speculates, "The thing is that he had made himself vulnerable to this kind of an attack. Someday this habit of his would have landed him in trouble for sure."

"What happened to the hacker's threat?" asks Elsa. "I heard some rumours about what happened, but since I'm not too sure, I wouldn't want to spread the news," Paathik replies, "but this is a big issue for anyone out there who watches porn. I would suggest that if you really can't avoid watching it, you can instead take a paid subscription on YouTube. It's more secure. Even so, you can't leave anything to chance. Make sure that your webcam is always covered with a clip or sticker. A common habit with blue films, or other downloaded films, is to share them. When that happens, the virus just travels around to new devices. Now you can understand why I was so adamant about a full anti-virus scan every three days. In his case, it would have detected the malware." "Yeah, now I see how horribly wrong things

could get,” Shrini figures.

"Something similar happened to someone I know," Yuvraj discloses. "He got involved with an unknown woman online and even got into an intimate video call with her. What he didn't know was that his actions were being recorded. Ten minutes after the call, he got a message with his compromising video and a threat to leak it if he didn't pay up." "So, did he pay them the money?" probes Manbir. "He had to because he is a well-known personality, and the video would ruin his career," answers Yuvraj.

"This is called cyber honey trapping," Paathik interjects, "and it's not surprising that it's quite common." "Cyber honey trapping," Ghazal comments, "that's quite a funny name for such a serious crime."

"Serious, and way too common these days," Elsa observes, "ever since devices got into our lives and our bedrooms, crimes have gotten way too ugly. Let me tell you about what happened to my friend, Ryan."

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BEWARE OF PEEPING TOMS

“So, I’ve known Ryan since college,” Elsa starts narrating, “He and his wife, Jia, are quite social – they love to throw parties at home.” “Maybe you should tell them about my company,” Shrini chuckles, “they sound like ideal customers.”

“I wish,” Elsa reveals, “but things aren’t like they used to be. This happened a year after he got into business with a close friend, Gaurav. This guy was at their home quite often; he was like family to them. Even I have met Gaurav at their place on some occasions.”

“One day, out of the blue, I got a call from Ryan, who asked me to refer him to a cyber expert. He had received a video of his wife being intimate with someone, and he wanted to know who had sent it.” “Was she having an affair?” Manbir asks. “That’s where the story gets twisted,” Elsa responds, “The cyber expert traced the link back to his office network. He was confused and decided to confront Jia. She immediately broke down and told him what happened. Gaurav had been blackmailing her with an intimate video of Ryan and her. He threatened to leak the video if she didn’t sleep with him. The worst part was that Gaurav knew almost everyone in their personal and professional circle and a leak would have been quite a blow to their reputation. What she didn’t know was that

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Gaurav secretly recorded them in bed too."

"That's disgusting," Piyushi remarks, "Poor Jia." "How did he record Ryan and her? And why?" Shrini questions. "Well," Elsa responds, "There was power play happening at work. Gaurav wanted total control of the company's finances, which Ryan was dead against. Gaurav decided that doing something like this would give him power over Ryan and make him stay out of his way. How he did it is the interesting part - on an investigation, they found out that Gaurav had planted a pen with a camera in their bedroom."

"These hidden cameras have gotten many people in a lot of trouble," Paathik explains, "but it's largely because they were lax about their privacy. No one should be allowed into your personal space, no matter how close they are; bathrooms are also out of limits." Shrini interrupts, "But that means that I'd have to tell my guests to hold their beer in till they get home." Everyone chuckles and Paathik replies, "Of course not! If you have multiple bathrooms in your house, it's always advisable that your guests use the one in common spaces rather than the one in your bedroom. You should also do a sweep of the house after a party to look for anything out of the ordinary. This could be in your wall clock, AC vents, mirror, alarm clock, soap dish, toothbrush holder, tissue box, pen stand, curtain rod, a hanging painting or even your DVD player. Did you know that most smart TVs with a camera can be used to record what's happening in the house? Like your phone, this too needs to be covered."

"So, are you saying that I need to snoop around the house after this party?" Piyushi adds playfully. With a laugh, Paathik continues, "Well, I noticed you've kept

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your bedroom door closed, and that's a good start. On a serious note, though, if this ever happens to you, please report it to the police and contact a cyber expert." "You can expect that call from me," Manbir says with a smile. "Of course, I'd be happy to help," Paathik replies, "but a general rule of thumb - always be cautious, instead of trusting everyone blindly."

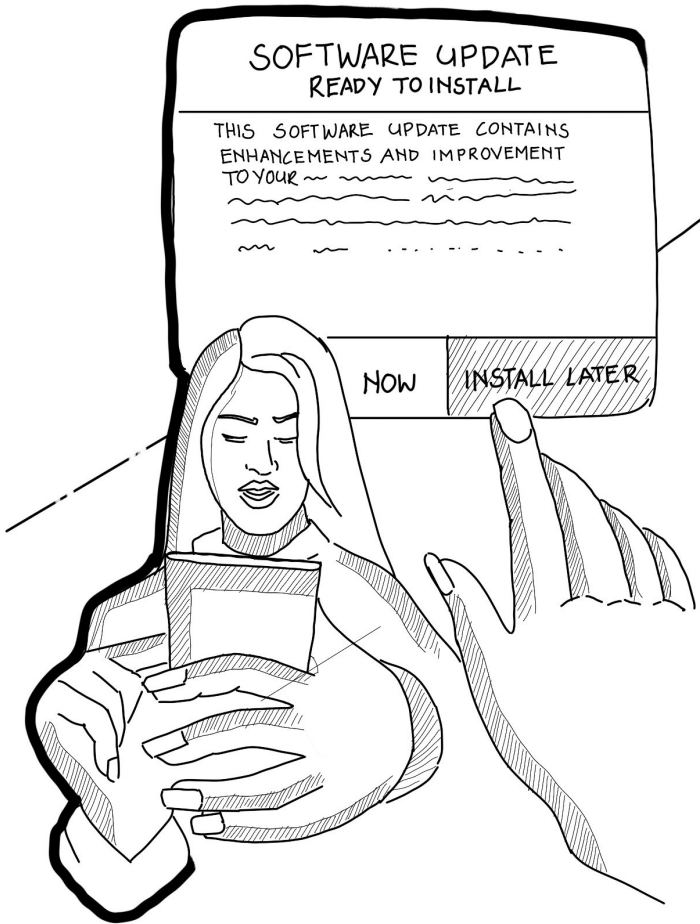
"So, Elsa," Ghazal questions, "what finally did happen with Ryan and Jia?" "With the help of the cyber expert, they reported him to the authorities," Elsa confirms, "but the case is still on."

"These love triangles and all get quite messy when you add a cyber angle to it," Manbir reveals, "A colony friend from back home got caught in this twisted web once."

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WHEN UPDATES ARE NOT UP-TO-DATE

"Sorry to interrupt, Manbir," Piyushi states, "but I have a sweet surprise for you guys. Give me a minute." She gets up and heads to the kitchen, as the rest eagerly await the big reveal. She returns, carrying a tray filled with bowls and spoons. "We all scream for ice cream!" she says, not being able to contain her excitement. Cheers and applause fill the room as they all thank their gracious host for making the night even sweeter. "I didn't know what everyone liked, so I got the staples – chocolate and vanilla," she says as they each take a bowl.

Digging into her bowl, Ghazal asks Manbir, "You were saying something about a colony friend?" "Ah yes!" Manbir recollects, "this ice cream almost made me forget. Good choice, Piyushi!"

"So, this guy, Shishir, worked at a telecom Value Added Service (VAS) company," Manbir begins. "Together with his colleagues, Pooja and Rohit, they quite the well-known trio. But the love triangle wasn't between them. Rohit married Ananya, someone outside of this closed knit group. A couple of months after their wedding, Shishir started receiving messages from Ananya. He didn't think anything of it at first, but then the messages started to cross the line. He didn't want to cause a crack in his friend's marriage, so he just responded

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casually. But when it became too much, he went to Rohit and told him about it. He confronted her, but Ananya denied ever messaging Shishir, even though they found all the messages on her phone. Rohit couldn't stand the lies, and he filed for a divorce."

"Did she ever come clean about sending the messages?" Yuvraj enquires. "Ananya didn't," Manbir answers, "but Pooja did." "What? How did Pooja do it?" Piyushi exclaims. "You see," Manbir clarifies, "About a year before getting married, Rohit and Pooja were dating. What he didn't know was that she still had feelings for him even after they broke up. She hid it so well, that he spoke very casually about Ananya to both of them. Once he joked that Ananya's phone was a security threat because she didn't install software updates. All because hers was an older phone, and she was scared that the software upgrade would slow down her phone. On hearing that, Pooja researched a bit about hacking into phones and accessed Ananya's phone quite easily. So, it was Pooja sending those messages from Ananya's phone."

"Why did she confess then? Wasn't she getting what she wanted?" Paathik asked. "Apparently, she saw how miserable Rohit was during the divorce proceedings and decided to come clean," Manbir replies. With a nod, Paathik takes over, "I guess Ananya learnt her lesson – never keep any software updates pending. These updates fix any bugs and add security patches. The minute a company stops supporting a particular device with software and security updates, it's time to upgrade to a new phone. In fact, why don't you guys check if your phones are up to date."

"I hope I can do this tomorrow," Piyushi sighs. The

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rest reach out for their phones; as Paathik continues, "Android users, go to Settings and navigate to System or Software Update. iPhone users, go to Settings, click on General and then navigate to Software Update. Is it all up-to-date?" While everyone else nods, Ghazal lets out a soft "Oops!" followed by a promise to update it as soon as she gets home. Paathik puts both his thumbs up and says, "That's great! Just make sure it stays that way. In Ananya's case, what would have happened is that Pooja would have planted malware on her phone, which gave her complete access to her messages. Without exaggeration, it's really not hard to do it. With some apps and tools, even a first-timer can hack a phone with old software. An easy way to save yourself from such a situation is to make sure that anti-virus scanning is always turned on."

"I've always been told to get a good anti-virus for my laptop," Manbir mentions, "but I never thought of doing the same for my phone." "That's quite common, actually," Paathik clarifies, "even those with the most expensive phones don't take the trouble to secure it. Everyone buys a good quality screen guard and a fancy cover, but never an anti-virus."

"This was quite an alarming one," Ghazal states, "for a different reason. I know passwords need to be protected and kept safe, but I always thought software updates were only about new features. Never knew that it saved me from security threats." "And jealous exes, too!" Shrini quips.

As she clears the ice-cream bowls and picks up the tray, Piyushi looks around the room and asks, "Anyone for seconds?" Yuvraj rubs his tummy and says, "Thanks,

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but I'm too full right now."

Suddenly, silence fills the air as the music playing in the background comes to a halt. "The net is acting up again," Shrini says after he checks his phone, "Piyushi, do you mind giving me your WiFi password?" "It's a bit complicated," Piyushi states, "let me enter it for you." "Sure," Shrini agrees, "Which one should I connect to?" "P-!-3-F-!" Piyushi says with a smile. "What?" Shrini gives her a puzzled look. "It stands for Pie-Fi, my favourite dessert," Piyushi reveals, "It may look complicated, but I've purposely done that so that no one knows it's my WiFi. There's an interesting story behind that."

"Before you begin that story, Piyushi," Paathik informs, "you can actually ask your computer guy to set up a separate guest login on your router. That way, you don't have to share your WiFi password with any one too." "Wow!" Piyushi says in surprise, "I didn't know that was possible. Definitely going to get it done." "Me too," Ghazal echoes.

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I SPY... SOMEONE USING PUBLIC WI-FI

“Don’t keep us waiting, Piyushi,” Manbir urges. Piyushi hands Shrini his phone after entering his password and begins, “This girl, Riya, was a DIY blogger. She started at a young age, and by the time she was 18, she was already earning and was quite famous. Anyway, her best friend, Roop, started dating this guy, Ankit, from college. Riya had met him a couple of times and didn’t like him at all. He seemed like a skirt chaser, and after a couple of months, she found out that he had been cheating on her friend.” “Now that’s going to end badly for him,” Yuvraj guesses. “Actually, in this story, it ends badly for Riya. She told Roop, who immediately ended things with Ankit. And a couple of days later, when Riya was at a coffee shop writing her blog, Ankit came in and saw an opportunity to get his revenge. He logged into the café WiFi and found that she, too, was connected to it. Within minutes, he hacked her computer and had access to the contents of her laptop.”

“That would have only been possible if she was in discoverable mode when she connected to the WiFi,” informs Paathik, “It makes it easier for someone to find you via the WiFi router.” Nodding, Piyushi continues, “Someone later told her that it was also because she used her name for her computer, so Ankit knew exactly which laptop to target. Once he got into her laptop, he got the

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login credentials of her blog and posted some sexually explicit content on it." "Oh no!" the group said almost in a chorus.

"Yea, her fans were quick to react too," Piyushi continues, "They insulted her, spread the word about what she posted, reported and unfollowed her too. She was so embarrassed that she shut down her blog." "I'm sure she was more embarrassed by what people said to her," Elsa claims, "It can be very traumatising to receive that much negative attention. People react too soon and too strongly, without knowing the full story."

"Yeah, cyberbullying is a major problem these days," Paathik adds, "It has ruined the lives of many people, causing a range of mental health issues." "That's probably why she stopped going to college," Piyushi informs.

"That poor girl," Paathik says, "she could have avoided all that embarrassment if she just hadn't connected to a public WiFi. These days, internet packs are so cheap that no one needs to connect to any public WiFi – mobile hotspot is perfect." "But you know how wonderful phone signals are these days. We saw it in action right now," Shrini says with a smirk. "Agreed," Paathik smiles, "but in those cases, I'd suggest keeping yourself undiscoverable with file or printer sharing turned off and firewall turned on. A simple Google search will help you with a step-by-step guide. And of course, like Piyushi rightly said, never use your name or nickname as your device name."

"I have connected to hotel WiFi's during events and seminars," Elsa confesses, "but I always make it a point to disconnect after I'm done using it. I even go to the settings and forget the WiFi so that it doesn't auto-connect

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the next time I'm around." "That's a good practice," Paathik applauds, "and everyone should do the same."

"This is also how she learnt that MACs aren't as secure as she thought they were," says Piyushi. "Is it?" Shrini quickly asks, "I've also been under the same impression." "Well, there are a lot of people who think the same way," confirms Paathik, "But malware is technically a MALicious soft-WARE. So, it can be sent in a form that's supported by any operating system. It's this belief that leaves a lot of people vulnerable to attacks. Irrespective of the system, a strong anti-virus is unavoidable as they are designed specifically for that operating system. Windows systems have an added security feature called Device Encryption. When this is enabled, any unauthorised individuals will only get encrypted data."

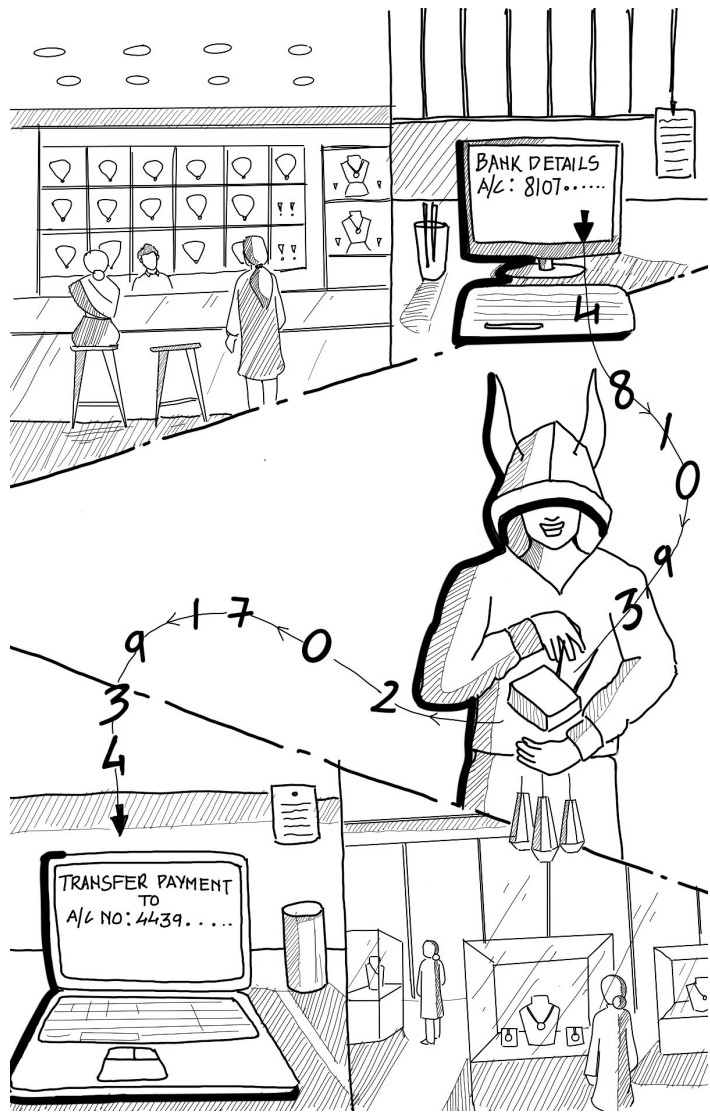
"Paathik, that's quite helpful," Manbir admits. "Actionable too, but before this gets any more intense, do you want to head for a break?" he adds, holding an imaginary cigarette. Paathik gladly gets up and joins Manbir on the balcony.

As Manbir lights his cigarette and passes the lighter to Paathik, he takes a deep breath, "Man, I thought only laptops and desktops could be hacked, but tonight I've learnt that phones and now even routers can be hacked! No one is safe, man!" "Dude, you have no idea how intense a router hacking can get," Paathik explains, "And it all started with a smoke break, just like this one."

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THE FAULT IN THE DEFAULT ROUTER PASSWORD

As conversation and laughter continued on the other side of the glass, the mood in the balcony was quite the opposite, with Manbir intently listening to Paathik narrate another story.

“What I’m about to tell you happened a few years back. Many gold and diamond merchants in the city lost large sums of money because their systems were hacked,” Paathik states. "And it all started with an innocent, hard-working engineer with a job in computer maintenance. This man, Rishabh, had a keen interest in ethical hacking and frequented many hackathons. During his regular smoke break at one such event, he bumped into some familiar faces. During their conversation, they casually got Rishabh to reveal details about his clients' network security and router models."

"And his clients were those gold and diamond merchants?" Manbir interrupts. With a snap of his fingers and an acknowledging nod, Paathik continues, "Correct! All the hackers had to do was smartly position themselves in one of the biggest gold souks in the city and use the default passwords for the router model to check for any matches. Lucky for them, 4-5 sets matched, and they planted malware to launch a middle man attack."

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"What's a middle man attack?" Manbir questions. "It allowed them to monitor their traffic, and at any time when the merchants shared account details for a bank transfer, they would swap it with their own. All the money then got redirected to the hacker's account." "Oh! I didn't know that's what it was called," Manbir says in slow realisation.

"Yes," Paathik confirm, "it's far too common, in fact. But while you may blame Rishabh for his loose tongue, he's not entirely to blame." "But he's the one who shared the details," Manbir says, confused. "The first mistake the merchants made was not to change the default admin password of their routers, and not just the WPA password, which you use to connect to the router. Every seller's website has these details easily accessible. Secondly, a router runs on low-level software called firmware. It sets the security standards for your connection, and it needs to be updated regularly so that you're armed with the latest bug fixes and security patches." Manbir, taking a drag, interjects, "So, it's pretty much how we update the apps and software on our phones, right?" Nodding, Paathik comments, "Yes, that keeps us protected against any new exploits. When someone comes to install your router, don't forget to ask him how it's done. But that's still not everything that they did wrong."

"There's more?" Manbir says in shock. "Some routers come with features to make remote access possible. With that turned on, it makes you even more vulnerable to such attacks. Besides, most remote access apps still work fine with this feature turned off. They also should have disabled WPS, *WiFi Protected Setup*, which lets you

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connect new devices with the press of a button or a PIN code. This makes it easier for unauthorised devices to gain access."

"So, if they had done all this, it would have saved them from being hacked?" asked Manbir. "Yes, and then it wouldn't have mattered as much that poor Rishabh leaked out some information. But there's one more thing the merchants did that caused their funds to get redirected. Can you guess?" Manbir, eager to know more, urges him to reveal it. "They shared their bank account details in the body of the message, which could be read. It's quite a common habit. But it's a lot more secure to share sensitive information like bank details as an attachment – an image or a document. It makes it that much harder to read."

Putting out his cigarette, Manbir confesses, "Paathik, I think this has happened to me." "What? Your router got hacked?" Paathik asks. "No," Manbir clarifies, "I think I was a victim of a man-in-the-middle attack. I've gone through this bank details issue."

Just as Manbir is about to share his story, Piyushi opens the balcony door and calls out, "Are you guys done? Manbir, you can't miss this story! It's about influencers getting hacked." Paathik too crushes his cigarette into the ashtray as the three head back into the living room.

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WARD OFF EVIL FROM YOUR WEBSITE

"This happened to my cousin's friend, Rishi," Shrini pauses as he opens a can of beer, "He was an influencer with his own YouTube channel for toy reviews." "There are influencers who review toys these days, too?" remarks Elsa. "It is quite a niche," Shrini agrees, "but I guess that's one of the reasons he became popular. He had some million-plus subscribers and was also earning money from endorsements and promotions. He got so popular that he was advised to create a website to host his content."

"Yeah," confirms Ghazal, "It's always better to invest in your own platform than relying on third parties." "That was the idea," Shrini confirms, "He even added an e-commerce section to sell the products he was endorsing. Just when the website was almost ready, he announced his plan online. He got a lot of support from his fans, who couldn't wait to see his website. But as always, there were a few trolls and haters as well."

"Yeah, there's always a mixed bag of good and bad in my comments section too," Manbir admits, "but the secret is just to ignore the bad ones as much as possible."

"True," Shrini remarks, "I wish he would have ignored this one guy, Swadesh. They had already gotten into a heated debate because of one of the products Rishi

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reviewed. Swadesh had bought something, wasn't happy with it and blamed Rishi for influencing his decision. Since then, he wanted to take revenge. He was a grey hat hacker, so he knew he couldn't attack Rishi via YouTube. But now that he was starting his own platform, he saw an opportunity. Swadesh impersonated a fan and sent Rishi a congratulatory greeting, which he innocently clicked on."

"Oh no," Paathik interrupts, "I can tell you that here's where it all went wrong." "Right on!" Shrini confirms, "Because Rishi clicked on that message, Swadesh got access to Rishi's computer, along with his files and login details. On the launch day, Swadesh replaced his website files with sexually explicit images and defamatory content about other influencers. His fans were furious, the media got involved, and his clients also withdrew their contracts."

"It seems like he didn't pay much attention to security aspects of his website," Paathik predicts, "What happened to Rishi is quite common and is called Web Defacing. While this hacker chose to replace files, sometimes, websites are completely destroyed. What would have happened is that Swadesh would have planted malware when Rishi clicked on the e-greeting. That would have given him an easy backdoor entry into Rishi's computer. Clicking on links in emails and even messages is a big NO."

"Yeah, I remember you suggested typing in the link text instead, right?" asks Yuvraj. "Correct," confirms Paathik, "And I'm guessing he didn't have a 360 Internet Protection. If he did, it would have detected the malware in a scan. But in Rishi's case, he should have conducted security audits and penetration tests for his webserver and

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application. These tests would have highlighted his site's vulnerability." With a sigh of relief, Piyushi comments, "I remember the guys I hired insisted on getting this done before I went live with my website. Right now, I'm so glad they did." "That's good, but you should also take a backup of website files," Paathik informs her, "that makes it easier to restore the site, especially if it has been deleted."

"What happened to poor Rishi, then?" asks Manbir, "Did he ever recover from it?" "A lot of people attacked him. He took down his YouTube channel and stopped creating video content. He tried getting a job at a toy manufacturer because he had so much knowledge about toys, but everyone in the industry had blacklisted him. Last I heard, he had moved out of the country. I'm not sure what he's doing right now, though." "That's sad," empathises Ghazal.

"It indeed is!" Paathik and Shrini exclaimed in chorus. "And these security basics need to start right when you decide to build your website," Paathik continues, "I understand that it's only practical that one would share credentials of the web server with their developers and designers, but a common mistake seen in over 95% of cases is that the password of the web server is never changed after the project." "Oh ya!" Ghazal agrees, "As a writer, almost all my clients have given me their credentials for work," Ghazal pauses, "One mistake at my end can cost so many brands dearly!"

With a nod, Paathik exclaims, "Absolutely! Let me tell you about a client's tribulation simply because she did not bother to change her web server password after her friend completed the website project."

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"Man! I am getting nervous now," Manbir says in worry. "Being an influencer myself, I can connect with Rishi's story, and now Paathik has another similar case!"

"Well, you'd be happy to know my client was not an influencer," Paathik informs. "She is an established architect and, just to be clear - this can happen to anyone, not just influencers," Paathik clarifies.

"I'll refer to her as Pari for anonymity," Paathik begins. "She wanted to build her presence online, and her childhood friend eagerly offered to help her out. Everything went smoothly, and the website was up and running in no time. But..." Paathik says dramatically, "a few years later, they had a fallout. Her friend got divorced and blamed Pari for it. Fueled by this anger towards Pari, she decided to take revenge."

"This is why I believe you should never work with friends!" Yuvraj explains. "I know what you mean, Yuvi," Paathik replies, "but life does not work that way. Rather you should be vigilant to be safe."

"So, what happened was that Pari's friend, or should I say ex-friend, used the web server credentials to delete every saved file, effectively taking down Pari's entire website."

"That's quite vicious!" exclaims Elsa. With a nod, Paathik continues, "This was just the beginning of Pari's nightmare. She transferred Pari's domain to another server and gained access to her company emails too."

"But how did she transfer the domain to another server?" enquires Piyushi, "I mean, Pari would be the owner of her domain, right?" Paathik explains, "It's common for people to ask their web developers to book

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the domain, so they naturally have the credentials. After that, it's a cakewalk!"

"Now Pari's friend was in control of her website, domain and emails, so her company's web identity and communication were both compromised in a matter of minutes," Paathik adds, "Pari's customers started receiving emails from her confessing that she overcharged and made a fool of them. She had access to the invoices that were saved on the cloud, so these were also attached to the mails."

"OMG!" Piyushi exclaims in shock. "That's not all of it!" Paathik announces. "For most of our accounts, be it social media or subscriptions, we use our email ID as the login ID. Pari did the same. All her accounts were hacked, and she lost access to her website, email, social media accounts, her employer access to a job portal and more in just a matter of hours. If that wasn't enough, abusive messages were sent to her clients on LinkedIn too. Poor thing, she hardly had time to react," Paathik sighs.

"I feel for her," Elsa sympathizes, "All this only because of one mistake of not changing her web server password." "Actually, no!" Paathik disagrees, "It's not one mistake but a bunch of bad habits that most of us follow." After taking a sip of his beer, he continues, "First, she asked someone else to book her domain. Come on, guys, it's one of the easiest things you can do." "I agree," Piyushi nods, "It's as simple as buying a dress online!" "Secondly, as you said, Elsa," Paathik continues, "she didn't change her web server password once the website was tested and went live. Thirdly, she used her domain email for all other accounts."

"Isn't it the best to use your domain email as it's

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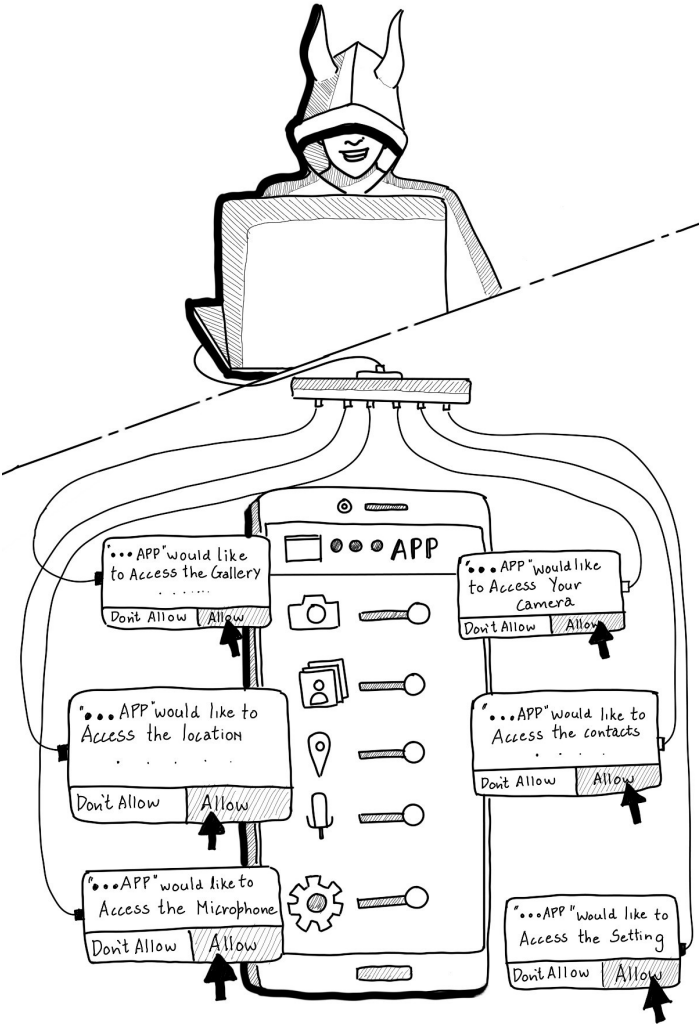
secure and in your control?" Yuvraj interrupts. "If your domain is compromised," Paathik clarifies, you lose access to all your accounts simultaneously, even if you have multiple email IDs. It would be smarter to use a public email service like Gmail as the recovery ID for email IDs you've used as login IDs. Lastly, she didn't activate Two Factor Authentication for all accounts. I can't emphasize this enough - if Pari had done this, she wouldn't have had all her digital assets compromised."

Nudging Manbir, Paathik whispers to him, "You were going to tell me something earlier. You want to head back outside?" "No, no," Manbir says, shaking his head, "in fact, I think it's something everyone could learn from."

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BEING APP-SOLUTELY CARELESS

“Guys, there’s a personal story that I’d like to share,” Manbir begins, “I know what I did wrong, but I’m not too sure about how it all happened. Let me just start from the beginning.”

"A couple of weeks back, I contacted my client who owed me money for a YouTube promotion, and I was surprised when he told me that he had already transferred it. When I saw the payment receipt, I realised that it wasn't my account number. I immediately checked my mail and realised that the account details I had sent were different."

"How did that happen?" Shrini enquires. "According to what Paathik told me earlier, I made the mistake of sharing my bank details in the body of the mail. A hacker intercepted that and changed the bank details to their own. But I don't know how they got access to my email."

"Well, it's definitely the work of a malware," Paathik confirms, "but I'm interested to understand how that malware got into your phone. The most common way is phishing. Did you click on any links in emails or messages from unknown numbers?" Manbir thinks and immediately pulls out his phone and starts scrolling. A few seconds later, he pauses, and turns his phone to Paathik, and asks, "I may have clicked on this link, but it

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didn't go anywhere. Could this be it?" Paathik takes a closer look at the message and speculates, "This could have been a phishing link, which is mainly designed to download malware onto your phone. It's important to never click on any link from unknown senders, no matter how tempting. Check to see if you've received messages from the number before. If not, you need to be more suspicious of it. In any case, as I had said earlier, it's always better to type in the URL of the link."

"I feel so foolish," Manbir admits, "but why would the hackers choose me?" "Well, hackers normally profile their victims before an attack," Paathik explains, "Their modus operandi is to normally get access to your SMS, storage, location and contacts so that they can assess your financial status and look for any vulnerabilities. With access to all of this, they have a lot of information about you, including where you go, how much money you have in your accounts, pictures of people you meet often, your most frequently contacted friends, and a lot more. The easiest way for them to get this information is via a scammy app. Did you download any recently?" "I try out a lot of photo and video editing apps for work," Manbir states with a shrug. "In all likelihood, you've given all permissions to one of these apps," Paathik points out as Manbir nods, "which is what caused all this chaos. Like I mentioned earlier, you need to be careful with the apps that you download. Check the reviews and ratings, and verify the app online. The biggest mistake you made was taking app permissions lightly and giving the app access to your data. For example, why would an alarm clock need access to your photos and contacts? Why would a photo editing app need to read your messages and track

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your location? In fact, after you download an app, you should go to the permission settings and see what all it has access to. If anything seems out of place, toggle it off immediately.”

Still in disbelief, Manbir says, "I didn't realise that such a small action could have such a large impact." "Well, even small mistakes cost a lot in cyberspace. Remember guys," Paathik adds, "don't share your bank details or other sensitive information within the body of your email.”

"In fact, Manbir, you were lucky you only lost money," Elsa asserts, "I know of a similar case where the girl lost way more. But before we get into another intense story, another round of beers?" "Oh yes! Definitely!" Yuvraj cheers. "Me too," Paathik, Shrini and Piyushi chime in chorus.

Back around the table with glasses full of beers, Elsa continues, "This girl was an app hoarder." "App hoarder?" Yuvraj questions. "It's a term used for a person with many apps on their phone," Ghazal explains. With a nod, Elsa resumes narrating, "She got a message that had a morphed picture of hers with a ransom demand and a threat to make the picture public if she didn't comply. Being a designer, she could tell it was an awful Photoshop job. Hence she ignored it. She received another message - this time from a friend, asking her why she was sharing such lewd images. She was shocked that the morphed image was sent to many of her contacts. That was when she got really embarrassed."

"She realised that the blackmailers could potentially send this image to her clients too," Elsa recounts, "but couldn't figure out how they got access to her contacts."

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"This sounds like the modus operandi of massive cyber extortion scammers," Paathik describes. "Correct," Elsa agrees, "they got access to her pictures and contacts when she downloaded some micro-lending app to check her credit rating. The app captured every bit of data on her phone and sent it to these scammers, who then used the information to blackmail her."

"I really feel for this girl," Paathik sympathises, "Nowadays, creating an app is cheap and hosting them on the store is quite simple. This, combined with people's habit of giving permissions without a thought, can be lethal."

"These scammers are waiting just around the corner to extort money from you if you fail to follow basic cyber hygiene," Paathik emphasises, "They have a very smooth mechanism to implement their plan. What they do is release the pictures in batches so that you are constantly under threat. I have dealt with cases where the victim's private moments were compromised by giving photo gallery access to apps. These were then sold to porn websites for a price or on a pay-per-click model. Scammers have many ways to monetise this data."

"So when we watch these clips on the internet," Shrini guesses, "We are actually helping these scammers make more money?" "Most likely!" Paathik replies. "I would suggest watching paid porn content on YouTube rather than any other free platform. I'm sure we all know by now what can go wrong otherwise," Paathik smirks.

"So, it's not just you, Manbir," Paathik consoles, "who made this mistake and got scammed. Many have paid a heavy price for their negligence while providing permissions to random apps. It's important that we check

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the app's reviews and ratings, but the most important question we should ask before providing any permission is - Does this app need that access?"

"Yes, I remember. I will keep it in mind now and surely take a look at all of my security settings tonight," Manbir says with gratitude. "Yes, I think we all need to do that," Ghazal reiterates, "and I'm really thankful to you, Paathik, for enlightening us on cyber safety. I'm sure everyone here agrees that we got to learn a lot from the stories today."

As everyone takes turns to thank Paathik, everyone pours themselves another drink. "Let's cheer to this night that has been interesting, enlightening, and a reality check for most of us," Shrini announces as he raises his glass. "We should do this again, guys," Yuvraj chimes in, "it's been great meeting all of you."

"Count me in, bro," Manbir says, raising his hand. "We should make a group on Whatsapp and plan it soon," Ghazal suggests, "Manbir, you can share tonight's pictures on that group too." "Sure," he nods as Shrini agrees to make the Whatsapp group. "Paathik, I'd love for you to take a session with my team at Safecity," Elsa requests. "It would be my pleasure," Paathik assures as he pulls his business card out of his wallet and hands it to her.

Just then, Paathik's phone rings. One look at it, and he says, "It's the wife. Give me a minute." "Oh wow!" Ghazal states, "I didn't realise it had gotten this late." Looking at his watch, Yuvraj lets out a yelp and says, "I'm sorry, guys, but I think I need to call it a night. I have a 5 am practice tomorrow." "Even I have a morning meeting tomorrow, so you'll have to excuse me too," Elsa

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echoes. Paathik, as he disconnects the call, nods in agreement, "Same with me, or else I'll have to sleep on the couch tonight."

As they begin to gather their belongings, Paathik emphasises, "But before I go, let me remind you guys to start with small things to keep your digital life secure. Download an anti-virus for your laptops *and* phones, set up two-factor authentication and don't forget to cover your cameras when not in use. Apps should only know, that they really need to know. Also, don't make the mistake of sharing any sensitive information or your passwords. Even after that, if you find yourself in a digital soup, you can get in touch with me." Turning to Piyushi, he advises, "Don't forget to remotely wipe the data from your phone before you give it for repairs. Because, once they put the phone on and enter the device password you have given them, the first thing your phone will do is automatically erase all the data on it. This feature works for both Android and Apple phones." After learning this information, Piyushi nods and says, "Paathik, you've been really helpful with this whole situation. Without your advice, I'm sure I'd be heading right for some trouble. Thank you so much! I'll definitely wipe off the data before giving it for servicing."

"Yes, Paathik. You have truly enlightened us," Manbir chimes in. "With that I would like to bestow upon you the title of Cyber Buddha," he says in a baritone. "That's a cool name, and we totally agree," Ghazal admits looking at Paathik. "Hahaha. I kind of love this new nickname" Paathik says congenially. "Cyber Buddha! Cyber Buddha! Cyber Buddha!" one by one they all start chanting this new title. After taking a courteous bow,

Paathik gestures everyone to stop.

Yuvraj then turns to Piyushi, and says, "Thank you for being such a great hostess. I had a great time here." He turns to Shrini and shakes his hand, "This was a great party, man. I look forward to maybe hosting my own one day, and all you guys are invited." After a round of 'thank yous' and 'goodbyes', the trio departs.

The rest of them settle down after a quick refill, and Manbir admits, "Man! What a storytelling session. I came here expecting some light-hearted stories, but this was a real eye-opener."

"Yeah, some of the incidents are just crazy!" Piyushi agrees, "I can't believe the lengths that people can go to for revenge."

"The scary part is that we're so vulnerable in the digital world," Ghazal emphasises, "Listening to these stories today made me realise that I'm not the only one who was foolish to fall into these traps." "That could have been any one of us," Shrini says reassuringly, "We don't even realise what we're doing wrong most of the time. But, thanks to Paathik's advice, I'm going to stay alert at all times."

With a nod, Manbir raises his glass and declares, "Let's all stay safe online and offline. If not, we can all bombard Paathik."

-----THE END-----

Paathik Muni \ Kamaljeet Kaur Muni

Wait! The story isn't over yet!

My friends and I may have left the party wiser,
but I'd like to give you a special recap.

Go through the list of dos and don'ts
and give yourself point/s for each one that's in your favour.

Total up your score and
find out how secure you are in the cyber world.



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Point if you stay away from these bad habits:

0		Handing over an unlocked phone to anyone.		1
0		Taking compromising pictures.		1
0		Sharing your personal devices with anyone.		1
0		Using weddings, birthdays or anniversaries as part of your password.		1
0		Taking your devices into the bathroom.		1
0		Sharing your card details with anyone.		1
0		Sharing your phone unlock codes, passwords, OTPs and PIN numbers with anyone.		1
0		Clicking on links in emails/SMS from unknown senders.		2
0		Handing over your Debit Card to anyone, or looking away if you absolutely have to hand it over.		1

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0		Shopping from unknown websites, especially those who advertise too-good-to-be-true offers.		2
0		Saving passwords on your browser.		1
0		Giving cookie access to any website.		1
0		Clicking on any pop-up ads.		1
0		Writing or saving your passwords anywhere.		1
0		Disclosing every aspect of your personal life on social media.		2
0		Tagging your location or sharing sensitive information about yourself online.		1
0		Downloading movies, shows or music using torrent.		1
0		Accepting video calls from strangers.		1
0		Welcoming anyone into your personal space like bedrooms and bathrooms.		2

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0		Connecting to public WiFi, and not keeping your devices non-discoverable.		1
0		Using your name or nickname for your devices.		1
0		Allowing anyone to tag you in pictures shared online.		1
0		Sharing sensitive information like bank details in the body of emails.		2
0		Not changing the default admin password of your router, and not just the WPA password.		2
0		Being lax about security settings on social media platforms.		2
0		Ignoring any suspicious and criminal activity, including cyberbullying, and not reporting it to the respective platform and the police.		1
0		Making payments online or on call before verifying any business phone number you find on Google.		1
0		Using free apps instead of paid, secure ones.		2
0		Publishing new websites without conducting security audits and penetration tests.		2

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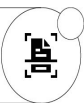
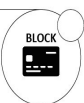
0		Not going through a company's privacy policy before sharing your personal details with them.		1
0		Not caring about software updates on your devices.		1
0		Not buying anti-ransomware tools.		1
0		Using duplicate or public chargers for your devices.		1
0		Leaving your laptops and desktops on even after use.		1
0		Using the same password for years without changing it.		1
0		Connecting external storage devices without scanning them first.		1
0		Shopping online without checking the company's return policy.		1
0		Being callous about who you add as friends on social media.		1
0		Never updating your router firmware.		2

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Point if you practice these good habits:

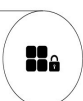
0		Creating a guest profile for your phone or laptop if someone else needs to temporarily use it.		2
0		Setting a PIN or password to approve the upload and download of data on your device.		1
0		Creating and using different passwords for different accounts.		1
0		Setting up two-factor or multi-factor authentication everywhere possible.		1
0		Keeping your keyboard or keypad away from prying eyes when entering a PIN or password.		1
0		Creating unique paraphrase passwords.		1
0		Keeping WiFI and Bluetooth turned off when not in use.		1
0		Covering your laptop's webcam and microphone, and your phone's front and back camera with a clip or sticker.		1
0		Keeping the firewall and defender turned on.		1

- | | | | | |
|---|---|--|---|---|
| 0 |  | Investing in a good anti-virus with web browser security. |  | 1 |
| 0 |  | Taking screenshots or screen recordings instead of downloading anything from unknown websites. |  | 2 |
| 0 |  | Using anti-threat detecting apps for unknown numbers. |  | 1 |
| 0 |  | Searching the web address if any link looks suspicious. |  | 2 |
| 0 |  | Scanning email attachments (especially zipped files) before downloading. |  | 1 |
| 0 |  | Taking regular data backups and saving them on the cloud. |  | 1 |
| 0 |  | Checking for a skimmer or hidden cameras before using an ATM. |  | 2 |
| 0 |  | Blocking your card if you suspect that it has been skimmed. |  | 1 |
| 0 |  | Checking the website of unknown brands for any glaring language mistakes or design glitches. |  | 1 |
| 0 |  | Going through Google reviews for an unknown brand before making a purchase. |  | 1 |

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0		Checking if the unknown brand has been covered by popular media.		1
0		Cross-checking discounts on popular e-commerce sites like Amazon.		1
0		Checking if the unknown brand has a registered address and phone number.		1
0		Disabling autofill on browsers, especially for sensitive information like bank and card details.		1
0		Downloading software only from a developer's website.		2
0		Creating a separate email ID for random registrations.		2
0		Using only established web browsers like Safari and Chrome.		1
0		Checking app ratings, reviews and developer before downloading any app.		1
0		Making sure the app you're downloading has been on the store for at least 2 months.		2
0		Taking a paid YouTube subscription instead of visiting porn websites.		1

0		Doing a sweep of your house for any hidden cameras after a house party.		2
0		Asking a professional to set up a guest login on your WiFi router instead of sharing your password.		1
0		Using mobile hotspot instead of connecting to public WiFi.		2
0		Turning off file or printer sharing when connecting to public WiFi.		1
0		Opting for 'Forget WiFi' after you're done using a public connection.		2
0		Enabling device encryption on your Windows devices.		1
0		Disabling remote access and WPS on your router.		1
0		Taking a backup of your website files.		1
0		Treating any SMS from new numbers with caution.		1
0		Giving only necessary permission to apps.		1

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0



Remotely wiping your data in case your device is lost, or needs to be handed over for repairs.



2

Your Total Score _____

If you have scored:

< 25 points: The Gullible Gorilla

You're in the danger zone as many of your habits might be leaving you vulnerable to attacks. Let the teachings of the Cyber Buddha in this book be your guide.

25-50 points: The Informed Iguana

You are aware of the dangers around, but you seem to have a lazy attitude towards it. Make sure you apply what you've learnt from this book to safeguard yourself.

51-75 points: The Alert Alligator

While you may have a natural gift for spotting potential threats, you're just a few steps away from being truly cyber safe.

75-100 points: The Clever Cat

Wow! You seem to have a superpower when it comes to cyber safety. Use it to keep protecting yourself and those around you.

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

PAATHIK MUNI

Paathik Muni has lived in the depths of technology and now dwells between the fine scripts of cyberspace. After spending over 15 years in the telecom industry, during which he engaged with large telecom operators and corporates on core digital networks, Paathik went on to pursue a Post Graduate in Cyber Law from NALSAR University, Hyderabad. This was in addition to his certification in Technology Entrepreneurship from Stanford University. He is also a certified Data & Privacy Auditor along with being a Advocate in Digital Law. With so many credentials under his belt, it's not surprising to know that Paathik has a truly unique understanding of technology, how it can be compromised in cyberspace, and the methods to litigate.

In addition to running a cyberspace consulting firm, Paathik is also the Head of a Startup Incubator at SIMSREE, a Global Mentor at WeWork Labs, and a Mentor at the Atal Incubation Centre. He has even taken his cyber safety expertise to numerous corporates where he has held training programs. His extensive experience in consulting on Innovation and various aspects of intellectual property led him to choose a more focused specialty and secured him the esteemed position of Chief

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Innovation Officer at Jagriti Enterprise Centre, where he oversees innovation and IP development along with implementation.

But it's not 'all work and no play' in Paathik Muni's life. When he's not helping steer clients to cyber safety, he is busy pioneering initiatives to fight social injustices in his home city of Mumbai. During the 2020 COVID-19 pandemic, he co-founded Khaana Chahiye, a non-profit organization to combat hunger and provide meals to the utterly destitute. In 2017, he co-founded Mumbai's largest apolitical voter awareness and mobilization campaign, Operation Black Dot, to bring the city's youth into the polling booths.

With a special corner in his heart reserved for our furry friends, Paathik is fighting the good fight to introduce a pet crematorium in north Mumbai, a first of its kind in the locality. He has also launched Stray Project, an initiative to support and sponsor good Samaritans working on the front line to help our animal friends.

The Good, The Bad & The Cyber Buddha is his first foray into writing – the first of many, he promises delivered in a digestible manner for the common man. *The Good, The Bad, The Cyber Buddha* is his first publication as a co-author, but definitely not the last.

KAMALJEET KAUR MUNI

There was a time when technology as we know it today was still in its nascent stages. So, while the world was skeptical about online shopping, e-books and all things tech, Kamaljeet was lapping it all up to understand its workings, discover its potential and asses its convenience. A true embodiment of an early adopter of technology and the digital space, she was shopping online at a time when delivery took a month, filling up her ebook library before a Kindle was in everyone's hands, and buying digital gold despite the thoughts of naysayers.

With her natural inclination to technology, she started her career in the field of digitization after a BSc in Chemistry and a Master's Degree in Business Administration from SP Jain along with a degree in Law. Since then, she has worked with organizations such as Hutchison, ICICI & Kotak, focusing primarily in the Telecom & BFSI sector, to develop technology-based tools and solutions which have been well-accepted and implemented. In her career spanning over 2 decades, she has worked on complex systems to deliver 500-odd projects in the Indian and international markets, many of which broke the mould and paved the way in the industry. With each project, she brings unique skill sets to the boardroom – an exceptional understanding of user behavior, her inherent knowledge of technology, and a heightened awareness of data privacy. Even before the term 'data' was on everyone's lips and contracts, Kamal

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(as she's fondly called) declared it to be the currency of the future – an uncommon thought for individuals in her industry at the time.

For her, tech solutions are meaningless if they lack the ability to make people's lives easier, albeit with a layer of strong security. Through years of keen observation, she prides herself in understanding human behavior. That's why when Paathik brought the idea of *The Good, The Bad, The Cyber Buddha* to her, she immediately gave it a user-friendly spin. For it to click with the right audience, she knew that the jargon had to be simplified, and the key takeaways needed to be delivered in a digestible manner for the common man. *The Good, The Bad, The Cyber Buddha* is her first publication as a co-author, but definitely not the last.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Writing a book has been harder than we ever thought, longer than we imagined, and so much more rewarding than we expected. Our ideas, experiences and mutual support could only take us so far; none of this would have been possible without the constant support, motivation and faith we received from our family and friends.

To begin with, we'd like to thank each and every character for giving their consent to be a part of the story:

Piyushi Jain, whose fun-loving, carefree and sugar-sweet personality added life to the book. Your happiness and smile can light up any room.

Shrinivas Shinde, without whose brainchild, this book would have missed its very integral setting of a house party. You're a brilliant mind who has constantly supported the idea.

Yuvraj Walmiki, the humblest celebrity we've met, for immediately agreeing to be a part of this modest project. Your positivity and dedication are a lesson to all. Also, a big shout out to his younger brother, **Devindar Walmiki**, for being an inspiring soul.

Elsa D'silva, a lady we look up to for her efficiency, determination and sharp focus. Your positive outlook and support mean a lot to us.

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The title of this book wouldn't have been as conceptual and creative as it is without **Harshil Shah** and **Gopal Kulkarni**. Thank you for dedicating your valuable time and energy to making this happen.

Harshil Shah, your creative direction and strong belief in the concept gave us the confidence to take this book forward.

Gopal Kulkarni, thank you for accepting this project like your own. Your in-depth understanding of the writing process and constructive feedback gave shape to this book.

To **Faye Rodrigues and Smruthy Nair**, who gave our idea the tonality and spirit it needed to become engaging. Thank you for adding your immense creativity to the book.

The illustrations that you see in this book are all thanks to the great, creative minds of **Khushi Jalan and Kiran Mohanty**. **Kiran**, a man with immense talent topped up with commitment is self-taught and has an evergreen hunger to learn more. Thank you for bringing alive the stories with your creations. Your dedication, hard work and honesty haven't gone unnoticed.

To **Darshak Padia, Jenil Parmar** and **Abhishek Singh** for their invaluable help when it came to designing of the book, even at the eleventh hour.

No words can convey our heartfelt gratitude to our literary agent **The Book Bakers** and **Suhail Mathur**, in particular. He is not only a terrific agent, but has also challenged us and believed in the story we had to tell. We are extremely thankful to have you on this journey with us.

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Paathik Muni would particularly like to acknowledge:

My parents, **Rekha Muni** and **Pankaj Muni**, for the constant motivation and the unconditional support at times of breaking points. They have helped both Kamal and me in managing not just the home but also our son when we were putting in long hours during some phases of the book writing process. Without them, this book would not have been a reality!

A special thanks to my sister, **Parina Mehta**, for instilling her confidence in this concept and being there at every step.

To **Shashank Mani**, for being supportive and morale-boosting when we needed it the most. A special thanks to you for gracing this book with your thoughtful foreword.

To **Deepak Chawla**, a man who has always stood by me, ready with words of advice and encouragement. As a first-time author, I deeply appreciate your insights into the publishing world. Deepak uncle, thank you for supporting my every career move.

For being ever-willing to fuel the message within the pages of this book, I'd like to thank **Anurag Mazumdar**. The scale to which you've mobilized assets to get our brainchild out into the world is a testament to your belief and support.

To **Gaurav Dagoankar**, for his invaluable feedback and support, be it with the book or the podcast. Your

generosity and advice with regards to the podcast world are invaluable.

To **Deepika Phakke**, for the positive affirmation towards the idea of the book. Thank you for also sharing your constructive feedback.

I've never considered myself to be a creative soul. So, it was terrific to have **Aarin Mehta**, a brilliant ad film director, provide his invaluable feedback. Thank you for sharing your creative perspective with me, brother.

To **Trushit Buch**, for the immense motivation, ever-encouraging words and sound advice. Your persistent follow-ups and gentle nudges kept us on track.

To **Prabhakar Nadar**, for his never say never attitude. Thank you for all the support, means a lot brother.

It wasn't easy for me to navigate the uncharted territory of video content. But **Nilay Thakare** gave me access to the right tools and ecosystem to bring alive our video content. Your experience and knowledge have guided me down the right path.

To **Prajakta Shirgaonkar** for her no deviation approach. You are an inspiration and thank you so much for always being available to help.

To **Anuj Mishra and Akhilesh Subramanian**, for their invaluable inputs in bringing this book out into the world. Your understanding of the market gave me the clarity I needed.

I, Kamaljeet Kaur, would particularly like to acknowledge certain people in my life. While they may not have directly influenced the book, each of them, in their own way, have shaped me in my career or taught me valuable life lessons, all of which I believe gave me the strength and experience to co-author this book.

To **VV Balaji**, who has always driven me to perform and excel in spaces beyond my comfort zone. With his continuous encouragement, I've learnt to believe in myself and utilize my full potential to explore the unknown, thus leading me to co-author this book - a feat I would have otherwise held off on.

To **Neeraj Sethi**, who taught me that *'there's always a solution to every problem'*. This attitude of yours has become a guiding principle whenever I'm faced with a difficult situation. A lot of what you've taught me has influenced how I approached this book. Thank you!

To **Mubashshera Kakajiwala**, a friend, a mentor, and a true woman of substance - thank you for always being there. I have a handful of people in my life who spark the energy I need to reinvent myself. Thank you for being one of them. The way you share your knowledge and experiences so effortlessly inspired this book's simple and straightforward storytelling approach.

Thank you, **Shernaz Pochkhanawala**, for introducing me into the tech world! My foundation in this world started at an early age when you gave me numerous opportunities and took an active interest in my passion projects. Just knowing that you're by my side fills me

with immense confidence.

To **Debabrata Mohapatra**, my coach, for always lending an ear. You've shown me how to step back and look at the bigger picture, and for that, I'm eternally grateful. Ever so often, we'd take this approach while shaping the narrative of this book.

Thank you, **Sheena John**, for being that person who has always had confidence in me, whether I was at my peak or at rock bottom! There is no better way to say it - *you are the food for my soul*.

I would also take this opportunity to thank a few noteworthy individuals who with their digital thought process have been shaping my views and approach to technology. Without the knowledge I garnered from them first-hand, I wouldn't have had the confidence to co- author this book.

Firstly, **Mr. Mahesh Balasubramanian**, who showed me a perspective that something 'Large' can also be 'Flexible'. His energies stimulate my mind to think out -of-the-box and break traditional barriers, the shades of which are evidently visible in this book.

Ms. Kirti Patil, the 'Iron Lady', who at the core understands that humans are not perfect and anything that is delivered has to be consistently bettered. I see her challenging status quo of the work that she has championed, in alignment to ever-evolving technologies every day. This motivated me to never shy away from improvising even if it meant changing the draft completely.

Mr. Hitesh Veera, a man who not only embraces technology, but always ensures that risks are mitigated at

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the same time. His multi-dimensional thought ensures that high quality products are delivered with required safety harnesses. This exactly, is the intention of this book as well.

Mr. DurgaPrasad Harichandan, for being a mentor and a guide who redefines simplicity, a learning which gave me the courage to experiment and write the book in a story format.

And finally,

Mr. G Murlidhar who is the epitome of customer centricity! His ‘mantra’ to always keep the customer at the centre point has been an inspiration to write this book from the readers’ point of view.

To my parents, **Narendra Pal Singh Matharu and Late Surinder Kaur Matharu**, and my brother, **Gurdeep Singh Matharu**, for being my protectors and guides. A heartfelt thanks to each one of you for teaching me to follow my passion and do my best without worrying about the outcome.

Lastly, I’d like to thank my husband and co-author, **Paathik Muni**, for presenting me with this opportunity. I’ve always been an avid reader but never thought of myself as an author. I’d like to believe that our combined experience and knowledge has helped create a book that will be helpful to every reader.

Together, we would like to thank:

Our son, **Reyansh Muni**, who, on some weekends, unwilling to part with us, always gave-in. His maturity at a young age has given us the space and all the love we needed to complete this journey.

Our wonderful team that efficiently managed all the finer details, so that we could focus on writing. Thank you, **Hinafatema Humza** for your positive energy and never-say-no attitude. You've been an excellent assistant. Many thanks to **Vaishnavi Sharma**, a young and talented woman who we believe will go far in life.

Finally, a big thank you to everyone who spared time and energy to share their valuable feedback: **Ankit Pandey, Kalp Seth, Payal Seth, Ankita Chauhan, Ankita Verma, Kamlesh Shah, Ankita Chokhani, Monica Raheja, Chirag Kakkad, Shrinkla Jain, Kavita Iyer, Apurwa Shrivastav, Mohan Azad, Yogesh Mishra, Shilpa Panchal, Padmalaxmi Panchal, Leena Aditya, Sidharth Desai, Shraddha Sane, Girish Kumar, Cassandra Nazareth, Vidisha Shetty, Hardik Kapdi, Abhishek Rungta, Vikram Karvi, Louisa Fink, Sameer Mehta, Arvind Gupta, Mayuri Joshi, Swati Sharma, Dinesh Shetty, Piyush Bhatia, and KK Mookhey.**

The Good The Bad The Cyber Buddha

we work

A very special thanks to **WeWork India** for being a catalyst for creation. The collaborative culture that is both encouraged and celebrated gave us access to an ecosystem where our ideas could thrive. A special thanks to the **community team at WeWork, Spectrum Towers, Ayushi Singh, Akash Mayekar, Jitesh Magnani, Benston Dsouza, Samson Dsouza and Faizan Khan** for giving our concepts room to grow. We tip our hats to **Uma Joshi and Waseem Shaikh** for their steady encouragement and support. It's through **WeWork** that we met and interacted with professionals that helped make this book what it is before you today.